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Constructing Childhood: Representations, voices and absence in the *Nordic Life* Exhibition at Nordiska museet

"What we choose to display in our public spaces, who curates our perspectives, who becomes visible to us in art represents a national conversation who "we" are" (Gabeba Baderoon, 2010).

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Abstract

Museums play an important role in preserving and communicating collective histories, but their narratives also shape which experiences and voices become visible, marginalised or absent. Although previous research has examined how museums represent children and minority groups, less is known about the representation of childhood in *Nordic Life*, a relatively recent exhibition presenting 500 years of life in the Nordic region. This study addresses three research questions concerning how children and childhood are represented, how exhibition elements contribute to these representations, and how children's perspectives are included, marginalised or absent. A qualitative interpretive research design informed by Childhood Studies and museum studies was employed. Data were collected through structured walkthrough observations during a one-day field visit, supported by fieldnotes and photographs. The exhibition was analysed as a curated and multimodal environment, with attention to objects, texts, images, spatial arrangements, visibility and absences.

The findings show that children and childhood are represented across *Nordic Life*, but unevenly across displays and historical periods. Representations are largely mediated through adult perspectives, while children's own voices and perspectives are difficult to identify. Childhood is commonly associated with family, education, play, vulnerability and social development, while children's own experiences and agency receive limited attention. The analysis also reveals a tension between the exhibition's Nordic framing and the predominantly Swedish focus of the material examined. Swedish history, culture and childhoods are particularly prominent, while distinct representations of the wider Nordic region are limited. Several minority groups are similarly underrepresented, extending questions of visibility and marginalisation beyond childhood itself. The study concludes that *Nordic Life* makes childhood visible as a cultural and historical category, but constructs a selective representation in which some childhoods, experiences and social groups are more visible than others, while the broader Nordic context is primarily articulated through a Swedish perspective.

Keywords: Childhood, representations, narratives, absences and museums

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Introduction

Museums often present themselves as institutions that preserve and communicate collective histories, however, this raises questions about whose experiences are included and represented. If museums aim to represent “us” it becomes important to examine whether children are visible within these narratives and how childhood is portrayed. Investigating the presence, absence and positioning of children in museum narratives therefore requires attention to the role museums play in constructing and communicating historical representations (Sitzia, 2023:154). Museums connect past, present and future by preserving and interpreting objects, experiences and cultural narratives. Through this process, they shape understandings of history and identity while influencing which perspectives become visible or marginalised (Boast, 2011:58; Caruso & Buzinde, 2025:2; Kalsås, 2015:33, 43–46).

This study examines *Nordic Life*, an exhibition at Nordiska museet presenting 500 years of everyday life in the Nordic region through approximately 4000 artefacts and images. Developed in collaboration with academic and museum experts from Sweden and across the Nordic countries, the exhibition explores social change, cultural traditions and everyday experiences (Royal Djurgården, n.d.; Stockholm Business Region, 2026).

Although *Nordic Life* has received limited critical examination, existing critiques have highlighted concerns regarding the marginalisation and underrepresentation of minority groups within Nordic historical narratives (Sveriges Radio, 2026; Bergendahl & Berggren, 2024; Persson Lahusen, 2025). These discussions demonstrate the importance of examining not only whose experiences are included, but also which perspectives remain overlooked. While previous research has explored minority representation and constructions of Nordic identity (Bergendahl & Berggren, 2024; Persson Lahusen, 2025), limited attention has been given to how children and childhood are represented within the exhibition narrative. With 865,738 visitors to Nordiska museet in 2025 and increasing international interest (Magasin K, 2026; Nordiska museet, 2026), questions of representation become increasingly significant.

Examining how children and childhood are constructed within *Nordic Life* therefore contributes to understanding how museums shape historical narratives and communicate ideas of societies and identities, as well as institutional heritage (Sitzia, 2023:154).

Research problem and questions

Museums play a central role in society by influencing how people understand the past and its cultural significance. Through the stories, objects and perspectives they present, they can shape both personal and shared senses of identity, while also determining which aspects of the past are recognised and preserved as heritage (Boast, 2011:58; Caruso & Buzinde, 2025:2; Kalsås, 2015:33, 43–46; Sitzia, 2023:154). As influential sites of knowledge production, museum exhibitions shape public understandings of history, identity, children and childhood, making museums an important area for research. However, limited attention has been given to how children and childhood are constructed within Nordic historical narratives.

This study aligns with central concerns within Child Studies regarding whose childhoods are made visible, valued, marginalised or absent and how power influences the construction of childhood narratives (Whitehead, 2024:12). Childhood is understood as socially constructed and shaped by factors such as ethnicity, culture and historical context. From this perspective, children and childhood are examined as subjects of study in their own right, while also recognising the importance of children's relationship to histories and cultural heritage (James & Prout, 2015:3–4).

This thesis analyses how children and childhood are represented and constructed in the exhibition *Nordic Life* at Nordiska museet. It aims to contribute critical knowledge about the ways in which childhood is portrayed within the exhibition. More specifically, the study examines how childhood is constructed through exhibition displays, objects, texts and narratives; which aspects of children's lives are included or excluded and how these representations contribute to broader narratives of Nordic history and identity. By focusing on children and childhood, the study addresses a gap in existing research, which has more commonly examined issues of minority representation and Nordic identity construction within museum narratives. This study addresses this gap by analysing how *Nordic Life* represents children and childhood within broader narratives of Nordic history and identity.

Research questions

1. How are children and childhood represented in the displays?
2. How do exhibition design, objects and texts contribute to the construction of narratives about children and childhood?
3. In what ways is a child perspective included, marginalised or absent within the exhibition?

Theoretical framework

The social construction of childhood and children as cultural actors

Representations are central to meaning-making and must be understood as systems of ideas through which social realities are constructed (James & James, 2012:99). Within sociology, childhood is understood as socially and culturally constructed rather than a universal biological stage. Its meanings vary across societies and historical contexts, shaped by norms, laws, class, gender and ethnicity. This perspective recognises childhoods as diverse and context-dependent rather than a single universal experience. (James & James, 2012:9–10; James & Prout, 2015:3).

James and Prout (2015:2–4) argue that children's social relationships and cultures should be studied in their own right rather than understood only through adult interpretations of childhood. The category of both "child" and "childhood" is context-dependent and influenced by historical and cultural circumstances (James & Prout, 2015:1). This perspective challenges understandings of children as passive recipients of socialisation and instead recognises them as social and cultural actors.

Culture is continuously produced and reproduced through human activities, practices and social relationships within specific contexts. Children participate in these processes through everyday interactions and practices, a process described as enculturation (Mouritsen, 2002:14). Children therefore do not simply receive adult culture but contribute to cultural production through their own expressions, relationships and activities. Sparrman et al. (2016: 257–258) distinguish between culture for children by adults, culture with children, culture by children and culture among children. While culture for children refers to adult-produced cultural material intended for children, children's culture refers to the meanings and practices children themselves create through play, creativity and social interaction (Sparrman et al., 2016:258–259).

This distinction is particularly relevant when analysing museum exhibitions, as representations of childhood may reflect adult interpretations rather than children's own cultural practices. Understanding children as cultural actors therefore requires attention not only to whether children are represented, but also to how their agency, experiences and contributions are recognised within cultural narratives.

Child perspective and children’s perspective

Analyses of childhood representation depend on how children are understood. As both an ideological and methodological concept, child perspective can be interpreted in different ways (Halldén, 2003:12; Sommer, Pramling Samuelsson & Hundeide, 2010:19). According to Halldén (2003:12), a child perspective considers children’s conditions, positions and experiences within the social and cultural contexts in which childhood is constructed. It differs from children’s perspectives, which centre on children’s own voices, experiences, and meanings. A child perspective therefore does not require children’s direct participation, but focuses analytically on their interests, social positions and cultural expressions.

This distinction is significant when analysing museum exhibitions because exhibitions are generally produced through adult and institutional frameworks. Examining whether children’s own experiences, cultural practices and perspectives are represented provides an important basis for analysing how childhood is constructed within museum narratives.

Visibility, absence and representation in museum narratives

Museums do not simply preserve and present historical knowledge; they also play an active role in shaping how the past is selected, interpreted and represented. (Hooper-Greenhill, 1992:17; Hooper-Greenhill, 1994:18–19). Exhibitions do not simply present existing historical meanings, they contribute to how the past is organised, interpreted and remembered. Consequently, museum narratives involve decisions about both what is represented and what remains absent.

Within this framework, visibility and absence become central analytical concepts. Examining representations of children requires attention not only to whether children appear in exhibitions but also to how they are positioned, whose perspectives are prioritised and what forms of childhood become visible. Representation is therefore understood as a cultural process through which meanings of childhood are produced, negotiated and legitimised rather than as a neutral reflection of reality.

Hall (1997:28–29, 61–62) conceptualises representation as the production of meaning through language and other systems of signs. Meaning is neither fixed nor universal but produced through culturally shared systems of interpretation. Representation is therefore shaped by social and historical contexts and by the ways in which people make sense of and organise the world. Representation is also a question of power. Hall (1997:259, 261) argues that those with the authority to represent individuals, groups or events can influence how they are understood. Through processes such as stereotyping, representation may reinforce unequal power relations by privileging certain meanings while marginalising others. From this perspective, museums do not simply reflect childhood as a pre-existing category but actively participate in constructing cultural understandings of childhood.

Applied to childhood, representation involves more than visibility, it concerns how children are positioned within historical narratives and the forms of agency afforded to them. Representations reflect assumptions about children's identities, capacities, social value and belonging. Analysing museum exhibitions therefore requires attention to how institutional practices shape understandings of childhood and influence which experiences are recognised as historically meaningful.

The visibility or absence of children in historical narratives must therefore be understood in relation to the institutional practices and power relations through which histories are produced. Gallagher (2023:397) argues that historical silences concerning children may reflect broader structures of power, including class, race and institutional frameworks, rather than simply the absence of children's voices or experiences.

Representation thus concerns not only what is displayed, but also which experiences are overlooked or excluded. It also raises questions of authority and positionality, who has the power to narrate the experiences of others and from which perspectives historical experiences become visible (Zalut, 2018:4–5). These questions are particularly important in relation to childhood, as children's experiences have historically been documented and preserved largely through adult and institutional perspectives. Historical narratives can therefore be understood as selective constructions that privilege certain experiences while marginalising others.

Together, Hooper-Greenhill's understanding of museums as sites of knowledge production, Hall's theory of representation, and perspectives from Childhood Studies provide the analytical framework for this study. This framework enables an examination of museums as cultural spaces where meanings of childhood are produced, negotiated and legitimised. The analysis focuses on how *Nordic Life* constructs children's visibility and absence, whose perspectives are represented and how museum practices shape understandings of children's place within Nordic history.

Previous research

Children´s representation or representation of children in museums

Previous research demonstrates that children and childhood have often been marginalised within museum exhibitions and collections (Roberts, 2006:155). Roberts (2006:152) examines how British museums represent children and childhood, focusing on their visibility in exhibitions and the different constructions of childhood presented through museum displays. She argues that children receive limited attention as a social category, contributing to their relative invisibility within museum narratives (Roberts, 2006:155, 162). When represented, children frequently appear through objects such as toys, school materials and clothing rather than through narratives that situate their lives within broader social, cultural and historical contexts. Roberts (2006:162) further highlights how museum representations can present childhood through limited and selective constructions.

Roberts (2006:154) also discusses how childhood is frequently represented through adult perspectives, including idealised understandings associated with innocence, play and freedom. Children may therefore be represented primarily through objects associated with childhood rather than through accounts of their lives and experiences. Such representations can contribute to a predominantly adult-centred understanding of childhood and to the limited visibility of children within museum collections and narratives.

Building on this discussion, Brookshaw (2009:365) examines the representation of children's material culture through a survey of curators in accredited British museums. Her study explores how museums collect and interpret objects associated with children and childhood. Brookshaw (2009:366) argues that representations of childhood are frequently influenced by adult nostalgia and romanticised understandings of children's lives. She distinguishes between the material culture of children and the material culture of childhood, highlighting how the latter may reflect adult understandings of childhood. Since childhood is culturally constructed and varies according to factors such as "country, social class, time and gender" museum collections and representations may provide only partial understandings of childhood (Brookshaw, 2009:366). Brookshaw (2009:379–380) consequently emphasises the importance of distinguishing children's own material productions from objects produced for or associated with children.

While Brookshaw examines adult influence on material representations, Gallagher (2023) investigates the possibilities and limitations of accessing children's own historical traces through archival collections. Through an examination of child art and writing held in Australian collections from before the Second World War, Gallagher challenges the assumption that only limited fragments of child-authored material have survived in archives (Gallagher, 2023:384–386). At the same time, she emphasises that archival materials are shaped by adult systems of collection, preservation and interpretation. The social and historical contexts surrounding children's materials are not always recoverable, meaning that archival representations of childhood remain influenced by institutional processes (Gallagher, 2023:388–389). This highlights the importance of considering how archival and institutional practices influence which aspects of childhood become historically visible.

Patterson and Friend (2021:167) further examine museum collections of children's culture by analysing the epistemological and ethical challenges involved in collecting and representing children's experiences during the COVID-19 pandemic. Their study demonstrates that children and young people continue to have limited visibility within museum collections, while collecting initiatives may reproduce romanticised understandings of children and childhood (Patterson & Friend, 2021:175). Drawing on the history of children's exclusion from museum collections, Patterson and Friend (2021:169–170) argue that museum collecting has historically privileged adult cultural production and material culture. Such practices can marginalise children's own knowledge, perspectives and cultural productions, reinforcing adult authority over how children and childhood are represented.

Extending this discussion, Le Guennec and Rose (2024:1–2, 13–15) examine children's clothing collections in French and British museums through analyses of museum collecting and documentation practices. They identify children's clothing as a marginal area of museum collecting and argue that such collections have rarely been subject to systematic collection and documentation. According to Le Guennec and Rose (2024:9–10), the resulting collections may provide an incomplete picture of children's everyday clothing and experiences. This illustrates how institutional collecting practices influence which aspects of childhood become represented in museum collections.

Taken together, previous research shows that museum representations of childhood are shaped by adult-centred perspectives and by processes of selection, collection, preservation, documentation and interpretation. This highlights the importance of examining not only how childhood is represented, but also how institutional practices influence which children, experiences and perspectives become visible within historical narratives.

Material culture and representations of childhood

Material culture is important because objects are shaped by social, cultural, and historical contexts rather than being neutral reflections.

Brookshaw (2009:367–368, 379–381) highlights that children actively assign meanings to objects and may use them in ways that differ from adult intentions. To distinguish between adult and child relationships with objects, she introduces the distinction between the material culture of childhood and the material culture of children. The material culture of childhood refers to objects produced by adults for children, while the material culture of children refers to objects that children create, adapt, or appropriate themselves. This distinction challenges interpretations that examine children's objects only through adult perspectives and emphasises that children are not merely recipients of material culture but also participants in its creation and transformation.

Brookshaw's (2009: 379-380) analysis further demonstrates that museum collections often reflect adult assumptions about childhood rather than children's own relationships with objects. She distinguishes between children's material culture and the material culture of parenthood, referring to objects purchased or preserved because they represent adult expectations of childhood rather than children's own interests (Brookshaw, 2009:368). Her study shows that museum collections frequently privilege manufactured toys, books, games, and children's clothing, while homemade toys and objects created by children themselves are less commonly collected.

Brookshaw argues that toys are particularly dominant within museum representations because they appeal to adults and often function as symbols of childhood rather than evidence of children's lived experiences (Brookshaw, 2009:379–381). Consequently, museum objects provide important insights into how adults have imagined childhood, but they must be interpreted critically because they do not necessarily reveal how children used or understood these objects.

Building on Brookshaw's distinction, Brandow-Faller (2018:20–22) places children's material culture within a broader historical and social context. She argues that childhood and material culture are not universal categories but are shaped by specific historical and cultural circumstances. Through an analysis of visual and material artefacts associated with childhood, Brandow-Faller demonstrates that objects do not merely reflect childhood but contribute to constructing ideas about children's needs, development, education and appropriate behaviour. Using Brookshaw's concept of the material culture of childhood and the material culture of children, Brandow-Faller (2018:23) develops the idea of “childhood by design”, referring to the historical processes through which objects, toys and environments designed for children contributed to the creation of childhood as a distinct social category.

Brandow-Faller (2018:22–23, 26–27) further highlights that objects associated with childhood cannot automatically be understood as evidence of children’s experiences. Commercially produced toys and objects often reveal adult expectations and social values rather than children’s own practices. She demonstrates that the relationship between toys and childhood has changed historically. Before the seventeenth century, toys were not necessarily understood as objects specifically belonging to children and could also serve adult purposes. The modern association between toys and childhood developed particularly during the Enlightenment, when changing ideas about child development and education contributed to the understanding of play as an essential part of childhood (Brandow-Faller, 2018:23, 26–27). Objects associated with childhood therefore reflect broader historical processes through which childhood itself has been defined.

Semiz (2022:399) further develops the discussion of children’s material culture by examining the relationship between toys and the distinction between the material culture of childhood and the material culture of children. Through a content analysis of previous research on toys, Semiz (2022:399, 402) investigates whether toys are primarily understood as objects created for children or as objects shaped by children’s own practices. She concludes that most research approaches toys as part of the material culture of childhood, meaning that they are primarily examined as objects produced by adults for children. This reflects the dominance of adult perspectives within research and contributes to understanding toys as expressions of wider social structures, values and expectations regarding childhood (Semiz, 2022:402, 410).

Although Semiz emphasises the importance of recognising children’s agency in relation to objects, she also acknowledges that children’s material practices are influenced by their social and cultural environments. Therefore, there is not one universal meaning of toys or one fixed understanding of childhood material culture (Semiz, 2022:411). Instead, meanings are produced through specific historical and social contexts. Semiz concludes that research on children’s material culture continues to be dominated by adult perspectives, demonstrating the importance of examining how objects contribute to the construction of childhood (Semiz, 2022:413).

While Brookshaw, Brandow-Faller, and Semiz primarily examine the interpretation of children’s material culture, Marsal (2025) applies these discussions to museum practices. Through an exploratory investigation of four museums in Chile, Marsal investigates how material culture associated with childhood can be identified and interpreted within existing museum collections (Marsal, 2025:7). Building on Brookshaw’s distinction between the material culture of childhood and the material culture of children, Marsal develops methodological approaches for recognising children’s presence within museum collections and argues that existing collections can reveal more diverse narratives of childhood when interpreted differently (Marsal, 2025:5–7, 14–15).

Marsal demonstrates that children’s material culture remains underrepresented in museums due to adult-centred collecting and interpretive practices. Her findings show that toys and photographs are among the most common objects associated with children, reflecting nostalgic and idealised understandings of childhood, including socially constructed ideas about play and gender roles (Marsal, 2025:11). She argues that objects connected to children have historically received limited attention because they were not prioritised within adult-centred societies, emphasising that objects are also expressions of power (Marsal, 2025:14). By reconsidering existing collections, museums can create more complex and inclusive representations of children’s historical experiences.

These articles demonstrate that children’s material culture is shaped by social, historical and cultural processes. Objects can reflect both adult constructions of childhood and children’s own material practices, while processes of collecting and interpretation influence which aspects of childhood become visible in heritage narratives. This raises an important question of whose experiences are represented and whose remain silent or absent.

Children´s visibility, silences and absences

Previous research demonstrates that absence within museum collections is connected to processes of selection, preservation, interpretation and knowledge production.

Macdonald (2008:15) argues that heritage-making involves selecting particular histories and material traces that contribute to collective identities and ideas of continuity. Such processes may also mean that experiences that do not align with dominant narratives become overlooked or silenced. This perspective is important for understanding children’s representation in museums, as children’s experiences have historically often been positioned at the margins of adult-centred historical narratives.

Research on Sámi representation illustrates how museums construct visibility and absence through institutional practices. Through discourse analysis of permanent exhibitions in two Sámi museums, Potinkara (2020:2140) demonstrates that museums may strengthen collective identity by emphasising shared cultural characteristics while overlooking internal diversity. Similarly, Kalsås (2015:33, 46) shows through a comparison of Sámi and Romani representation in Norwegian museums that institutional authority influences which perspectives become visible. Baglo's (2019:25–27, 39–40) historical analysis of ethnographic exhibitions in Tromsø further demonstrates how narrow ideas of "authentic" Sámi culture contributed to the marginalisation of Sea Sámi experiences, while Silvén (2019:96–106) shows how collecting practices at the Nordic Museum privileged certain representations of Sámi culture. Together, these studies demonstrate that museum silences are produced through choices concerning collecting, interpretation and representation rather than simply reflecting the absence of historical experiences.

Similar processes can be identified in research concerning children and childhood. Le Guennec and Rose (2024:1–3) examine children's clothing collections in French and British museums and demonstrate that childhood heritage remains marginal within museum practices. Their findings show that preserved children's garments often represent socially privileged childhoods and exceptional occasions, while everyday experiences are less visible. This illustrates that museum collections do not represent childhood as a universal experience but are shaped by social and cultural factors influencing which childhoods become preserved.

Gallagher (2023:396–397) similarly examines children's visibility within archival collections and argues that archival silences should not be interpreted as evidence that children's experiences were absent. Instead, they reflect the social, political and institutional processes through which some experiences are preserved while others remain marginalised.

Gallagher highlights how factors such as race, class, disability and Indigenous identity influence which childhood experiences become recognised within historical records. Kestere et al. (2024:939–940) identify comparable patterns in Latvian museum collections, demonstrating limited representation of children with special needs and limited visibility of material culture produced by children themselves.

Marsal (2025:12–13) further demonstrates how reinterpretation of existing collections can reveal childhood experiences that have previously remained overlooked. Through analysis of photographic archives, she identifies representations of childhood experiences often absent from museum narratives, including child labour, institutionalised children and

Indigenous children's lives. However, she also shows that continued absences are connected not only to gaps in collections but also to broader challenges in research, interpretation, and curatorial practices.

Patterson and Friend (2021:174) similarly examine children's representation in COVID-19 collecting practices and argue that children's contributions were often reduced to symbolic objects rather than recognised as complex historical experiences. Their findings demonstrate that institutional decisions influence which forms of childhood become considered historically meaningful.

Taken together, previous research demonstrates that children's visibility within museums is shaped by processes of selection, interpretation and institutional priorities.

Studies of minority representation show how museums can privilege certain narratives while marginalising others, while research on childhood demonstrates similar patterns in relation to children's experiences. These studies highlight that silences surrounding children in museums should not be understood simply as a lack of historical evidence but as the result of cultural and institutional processes that influence whose experiences become visible.

Methodology

Research Design

This study is situated within the field of Childhood Studies and draws on perspectives from museum studies to examine how children and childhood are represented within the Nordic Life exhibition. A qualitative interpretive research design is employed to analyse how children and childhood are made visible, represented, positioned or marginalised through exhibition practices.

The study approaches the exhibition as a curated and multimodal environment where meaning is produced through the interaction of objects, texts, visual materials and spatial arrangements (Whitehead, 2025:34–37, 73–75, 81–83, 90–94, 98–99, 174). The purpose of the analysis is not to evaluate the exhibition, but to examine how representations of children and childhood are constructed and communicated within the museum environment.

Although the entire Nordic Life exhibition was considered during fieldwork in order to understand its overall narrative structure, the detailed analysis focused specifically on exhibition elements connected to children and childhood. The analytical focus was directed towards how children were represented, which childhood experiences became visible, how children's perspectives were positioned and which forms of childhood remained absent or marginalised.

The analysis adopts a child perspective, understood as an analytical orientation that considers the position and conditions of children within their social context (Halldén, 2003:14–17). Rather than treating children solely as objects of adult representation, the analysis examines how children and childhood are positioned and represented within the exhibition. This differs from children's perspectives, which refers to children's own views, experiences, and interpretations. Five recurring analytical themes structure the analysis: children's visibility and absence, representations of childhood, representations of children's agency, adult-centred perspectives and curatorial choices in the representation of children and childhood. The analysis also considers how display elements and narrative structures contribute to the representation and framing of children and childhood (Whitehead, 2025:17–18, 182–183).

The analysis treats the exhibition as a constructed historical narrative rather than as a neutral presentation of the past. It therefore examines how children and childhood are positioned within the exhibition by analysing three interconnected aspects: the selection and presentation of objects, the textual framing of these objects and their placement within the exhibition's spatial and thematic organisation. Particular attention is paid to what aspects of children's lives are made visible or remain absent, how objects and texts are connected to broader historical themes and what forms of childhood are thereby foregrounded (Whitehead, 2025:128, 175, 181, 213–215). This approach makes it possible to examine how the exhibition constructs particular representations of children and childhood within its broader historical narrative.

Data Collection

Data collection was conducted through structured walkthrough observations during a one-day field visit on the 21 of May 2026. The walkthrough method was selected because it enables analysis of exhibitions as spatial and sequential narratives, where meaning is produced through movement, placement and visitor progression (Whitehead, 2025:17, 34–37, 81–82, 174).

The walkthrough began with the exhibition as a whole in order to understand its organisation, themes and overarching narrative structure. Following this initial overview, the documentation and detailed analysis focused on sections, objects, texts, images and spatial arrangements related to children and childhood. This approach allowed the study to examine representations of children within the wider context of the exhibition rather than treating individual displays as isolated examples.

During the walkthroughs, attention was directed towards:

- where children and childhood appeared within the exhibition,
- how children were represented through objects, images, and texts,
- whether children were presented as active participants or passive subjects,
- whose childhood experiences were included or excluded and
- what adult institutional perspectives shaped representations of childhood.

The walkthrough method enabled analysis of how different exhibition elements function together to communicate meaning (Whitehead, 2025: xviii, 7–8, 33, 35). While the method focuses on the exhibition itself, the study also recognises that displays are shaped by wider institutional contexts, including collection histories, curatorial practices and organisational priorities (Rose, 2023:229–230; Whitehead, 2025:215–216).

Fieldnotes and photographs were produced during the field visit using a structured observational protocol developed from the research questions and analytical themes, see Appendix A.

The photographic documentation includes material depicting or relating to children, however, not all of these photographs are reproduced in this thesis. The images included were selected based on their relevance to the research questions and the analytical focus of the study. Some images were photographed by the researcher during the analysis, while others were obtained from the Nordic Museum. Images from the Nordic Museum were used where their higher visual quality provided a clearer representation of the objects, displays or visual details discussed. The images presented should therefore be understood as a selected representation of the exhibition rather than a complete visual documentation of all representations of children. Photographs were used as analytical documentation to support the subsequent examination of exhibition design, object positioning, spatial relationships and visual composition.

The protocol guided observations of the spatial organisation of the exhibition, the selection and presentation of objects, exhibition texts, visual materials and representations of children and childhood. Particular attention was given to children’s visibility and absence, representations of childhood and agency, adult-centred perspectives, the inclusion or absence of children’s perspectives and the positioning of children and childhood within broader historical narratives. The protocol was used to structure observations systematically across the exhibition while allowing for additional observations that emerged during the walkthrough.

The collected material enabled systematic re-examination of the exhibition after the field visit. This process supported analysis of spatial arrangements, representational patterns, and curatorial choices during the later analytical stage.

Data analysis

The empirical material, consisting of fieldnotes and photographs, was analysed through a systematic and iterative coding and interpretive process. The analysis was conducted from the position of a "critical museum visitor", examining not only what was explicitly displayed but also how meanings were produced through selection, arrangement and interpretation.

The analysis adopted a child perspective, understood as an analytical orientation that considers the position and conditions of children within their social context (Halldén, 2003:14–17). Rather than treating children solely as objects of adult representation, this perspective directed attention to how children and childhood were positioned and represented within the exhibition. It therefore informed the selection of material, the coding process and the subsequent interpretation. The analytical procedure consisted of five steps.

First, the empirical material was reviewed in its entirety. The fieldnotes and photographs were examined together to establish an overall understanding of the exhibition and to identify elements related to children and childhood. At this stage, no final interpretation was made. The purpose was to become familiar with the material and to identify potentially relevant exhibition elements, including objects, texts, photographs, displays and spatial arrangements.

Second, the material relevant to the research questions was selected for closer analysis. An exhibition element was selected when it contributed to the representation or construction of children or childhood, or when its textual, visual, material or spatial organisation was relevant to one or more of the research questions. The selected elements were retained together with the corresponding fieldnotes and photographs in order to preserve their exhibition context.

Third, the selected material was coded according to the coding framework presented in Figure 1. The framework was developed directly from the three research questions and consisted of three interconnected coding areas:

Figure 1. Coding framework linking the research questions to the analytical coding categories.

Each selected exhibition element was considered in relation to the coding areas. The first coding area was used to identify how children and childhood were represented, including who was represented, how children were characterised and what roles were assigned to them. The second was used to examine how objects, texts, photographs and spatial arrangements contributed to narratives about children and childhood. The third was used to examine how a child perspective was included, marginalised or absent, including the extent to which children were positioned as active subjects and whether particular experiences or positions were made visible or left unrepresented. Where an element was relevant to more than one research question, it was considered under more than one coding area.

Fourth, the coded material was compared within and across the coding areas**.** Within each category, the material was examined for recurring patterns, differences, contrasts and absences. Texts, photographs, objects and spatial arrangements were therefore not analysed solely as separate units, but also in relation to their placement and combination within the exhibition. This step was used to identify broader patterns in how children and childhood were constructed across the exhibition.

Questions	**Coding**
1. How are children and childhood represented in the displays of the exhibition Nordic Life?	Representations of children and constructions of childhood.
2. How do exhibition design, objects, and texts construct narratives about children and childhood?	Childhood narratives, material and exhibition constructions of childhood.
3. In what ways a child perspective included, marginalised, or absent in the exhibition?	Agency and voice, absences and marginalisations.

Fifth, the identified patterns were interpreted in relation to the research questions and theoretical framework. The interpretation drew on Rose’s emphasis on the institutional production of discourse and Whitehead’s focus on governance, power relations and the political dimensions of knowledge production (Rose, 2023:229–230, 241–242; Whitehead, 2025:12–17, 206, 214–215). The analysis considered how particular representations could contribute to legitimising and normalising specific understandings of children and childhood, as well as how institutional and curatorial choices shaped what became visible, marginalised or absent (Rose, 2023:6, 43–44, 229–230, 237, 241–242; Whitehead, 2025:16–18, 32, 36, 73, 174).

Throughout the process, the analysis remained iterative. When comparison of coded material raised questions about the interpretation of an element, the relevant fieldnote, photograph and exhibition context were revisited. Similarly, when an element appeared to relate to more than one coding area, it was reconsidered in relation to the other relevant category. The coding framework therefore provided a consistent structure for the analysis while allowing the interpretation to develop through repeated movement between the empirical material, the research questions and the theoretical concepts.

The analysis also considered the exhibition as a material and spatial environment. Objects, texts, photographs and spatial arrangements were examined in relation to one another and to the visitor's encounter with the exhibition. Drawing on visual and exhibition analysis, attention was given to how these elements contributed to the production of meaning and shaped representations of children and childhood (Rose, 2023:229–230; Whitehead, 2025:34–37, 73, 90–91, 98–99, 174). Exhibition environments may also be emotionally coded, meaning that spatial arrangements, objects and visual elements can contribute to particular emotional responses among visitors (Whitehead, 2025:34–37, 73–74, 90–92, 98–100, 174–175). This dimension was considered where the spatial and material organisation of the exhibition contributed to how representations of children and childhood could be encountered.

The purpose of the coding was not to quantify the occurrence of particular elements. Rather, coding provided a transparent and systematic way of organising the empirical material in relation to the research questions and of tracing how the subsequent interpretations were developed. Given the complexity of exhibition environments, the analysis was necessarily selective and did not aim to provide an exhaustive description of the exhibition. Instead, it focused on elements relevant to the research questions and examined these in depth (Whitehead, 2025:219–220).

Trustworthiness and authenticity

Trustworthiness

In qualitative research, trustworthiness is commonly assessed through four criteria: credibility, transferability, dependability and confirmability (Clark et al., 2021: 363–364). In this study, these criteria were addressed through a systematic and transparent approach to the analysis of the exhibition *Nordic Life*.

Credibility concerns whether the findings provide a convincing representation of the phenomenon under study. In this study, credibility was supported by systematically analysing the exhibition in relation to the three research questions. The empirical material was organised through a structured observational protocol presented in Appendix A, which guided the analysis of representations of children and childhood including exhibition design adult-centred perspectives, curatorial framing and children's perspectives including visibility, marginalisation and absence. Interpretations were grounded in specific elements of the exhibition, such as objects, texts, images and spatial arrangements.

Transferability refers to the extent to which findings may be relevant beyond the specific context in which they were produced (Clark et al., 2021: 365–366). Since this study focuses on a single exhibition, *Nordic Life*, the aim is not to generalise the findings to all museum exhibitions. Instead, transferability is supported by providing detailed descriptions of the exhibition, its material and spatial features, and its representations of children and childhood. This enables readers to assess whether the findings may be relevant to other museum contexts or studies of childhood representation.

Dependability concerns the transparency and consistency of the research process (Clark et al., 2021: 364, 366). In this study, dependability was addressed by clearly documenting how the research questions were translated into the coding framework and how the framework was used to organise and analyse the empirical material. The analysis followed the same analytical categories across the material, while the interpretation remained closely connected to the research questions and the empirical material.

Confirmability concerns the extent to which findings are grounded in the empirical material rather than primarily reflecting the researcher's assumptions (Clark et al., 2021: 364, 366). As interpretation is an inherent part of qualitative research, complete objectivity is not assumed. Instead, confirmability was addressed by relating interpretations to specific features of the exhibition and by distinguishing between what was explicitly represented and how these representations were interpreted. This reflexive approach helped ensure that the findings remained grounded in the empirical material.

Authenticity

In this study, the analysis of the exhibition *Nordic Life* is guided by Lincoln and Guba's criteria of authenticity, which include five dimensions of authenticity; fairness, ontological, educative, catalytic and tactical authenticity (Clark et al., 2021:366).

Fairness in this study relates to how various representations of childhood are included, excluded, or prioritised within the exhibition. Ontological authenticity concerns how the analysis contributes to a deeper understanding of how childhood is constructed through these representations. Educative authenticity addresses whether the exhibition allows for engagement with multiple or differing perspectives on childhood. Catalytic authenticity refers to the extent to which examining these representations and absences may prompt critical reflection on how childhood is presented. Tactical authenticity considers whether the study offers concepts for thinking differently about how childhood can be represented in exhibition contexts. These dimensions enable a critical examination of how childhood is constructed, whose narratives are foregrounded and which perspectives remain marginalised or absent within the exhibition (Clark et al., 2021: 366).

Implications

The methodological approach adopted in this study has implications for how the findings should be understood and interpreted. Grounded in a social constructivist and interpretive framework, the study does not aim to produce objective or generalisable knowledge.

The analysis is shaped by positionality. As Whitehead (2025:213–214) emphasises, both museum displays and their analysis involve processes of positioning: exhibitions situate visitors within particular historical narratives, while researchers interpret these positions through their own social, cultural and theoretical perspectives. The findings therefore represent a specific analytical standpoint rather than universally applicable conclusions. Following Whitehead (2025:214), this study offers one critical reading shaped by engagement with Childhood Studies and museum theory.

The relational nature of exhibition analysis also means that displays must be understood in relation to broader institutional, historical and cultural contexts (Whitehead, 2025:215). Focusing on a single exhibition and one field visit limits insight into wider institutional practices, curatorial decisions, changes over time and different visitor experiences. The findings therefore represent one situated encounter rather than an exhaustive account. At the same time, qualitative exhibition analysis prioritises depth over breadth, allowing for nuanced insights into representational practices.

The reliance on observational data rather than interviews with curators or visitors constitutes a further limitation. As Whitehead (2025:217) notes, producer interviews can provide insight into curatorial intentions and differences between intended and perceived meanings. Without such data, the analysis is based primarily on the exhibition itself. This also enables an independent critical reading that is not constrained by institutional narratives.

Reflexivity was integral to the research process, as the researcher's position influences how museum representations are observed, interpreted and analysed (Bryman, 2016:133, 364, 366; Rose, 2023:244–245). The researcher's dual position as visitor and analyst informed the fieldwork, with attention directed towards how children and childhood were made visible, positioned or absent through exhibition choices. Reflexivity was further supported through fieldnotes, photographs and a qualitative coding framework developed from the research questions (see Figure 1), providing transparency in how observations were selected, organised and interpreted. Following Rose (2023:87, 244–246), the analysis therefore sought to construct a transparent and theoretically informed reading of the power relations involved in the selection and interpretation of children and childhood within *Nordic Life*.

Analytical structure

The methodological approach described above provides the foundation for the analysis. The analysis is structured around the central themes identified through the qualitative coding process and addresses the study's three research questions.

The first section examines how children and childhood are represented and made visible within the *Nordic Life* exhibition, including how children are positioned within its narratives. The second analyses how exhibition design, objects, texts and visual materials contribute to the construction of narratives about children and childhood through material, spatial, and curatorial choices. The final section addresses inclusion, marginalisation and absence by examining whose childhoods and perspectives are represented, whose experiences remain less visible and how children's voices are positioned within the exhibition.

Together, these themes provide the basis for a critical analysis of how children and childhood are constructed within the museum environment and for answering the study's three research questions.

Analysis

Nordic Life is Nordiska museum’s permanent main exhibition, presenting life in the Nordic region over approximately 500 years. The exhibition takes visitors on a chronological journey from the early sixteenth century to the present day, intertwined with the changing Nordic seasons. The journey begins in midwinter, see Figure 2, and moves through spring and summer and reaches late autumn and the present day before ending in a future forest that changes with the seasons, Figure 3, (Nordiska Museet, 2026).

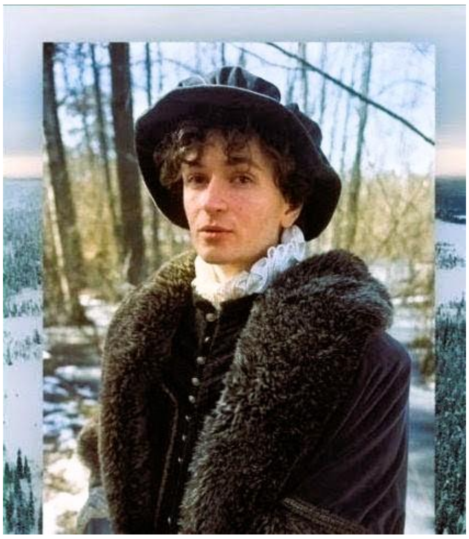


Figure 2. A young man in a winter landscape.

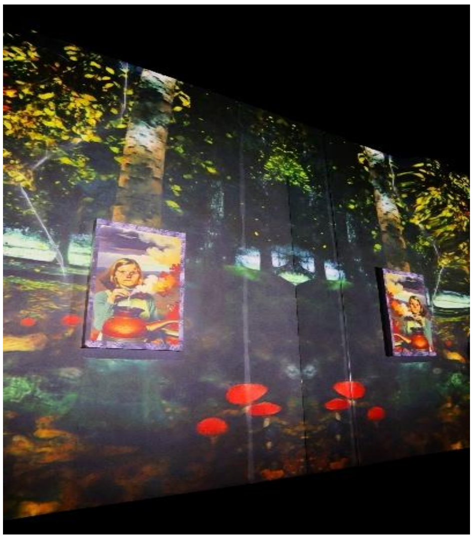


Figure 3. Sommer in a futuristic forest.

Across 27 rooms designed using scenographic principles, approximately 4000 objects are displayed alongside images, texts, films and individual life stories (Nordiska museet, 2026).The exhibition explores Nordic life and culture through themes including everyday life, family and home (Nordiska museet, 2026).Children and childhood are represented across these contexts rather than as a distinct theme, providing the basis for analysing how childhood is constructed through the exhibition's objects, design and narratives.

6.1 Representations of children and childhood

The representation of children and childhood varies considerably throughout *Nordic Life*. Although the exhibition spans approximately five centuries of Nordic history, children are unevenly represented across historical periods, primarily through material culture and family-related narratives rather than their own perspectives. Children most often appear as family members, recipients of care or symbols of broader historical developments, while their experiences, voices and interpretations remain comparatively limited.

Childhood as absence in the sixteenth century

In the earliest section of *Nordic Life* (early 16th-century), a large digital image depicts a young person in front of a display case. However, it remains unclear whether the figure represents a child or adolescent, a historical person, or a symbolic illustration., see Figure 4.

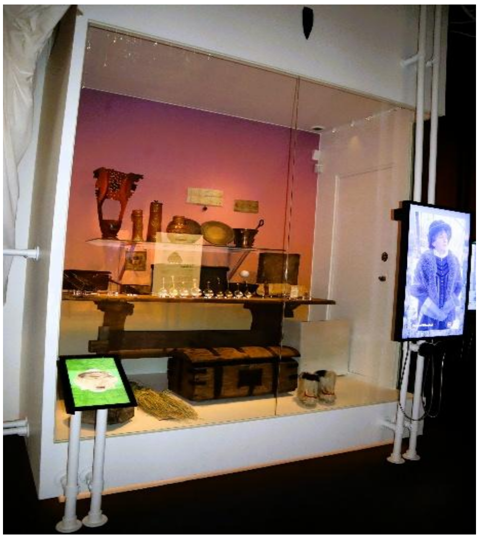


Figure 4. In front of a display featuring objects from the 16th century a screen showing a young man.

As Figure 5 and Figure 6 shows, the exhibition contains no clearly identifiable childhood objects, personal stories or interpretive texts relating to children's lives during the 16th-century.

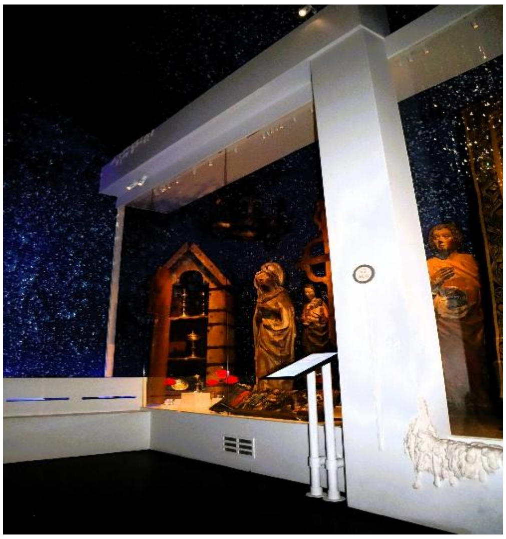


Figure 5. Display featuring various religious objects from the 16th century.

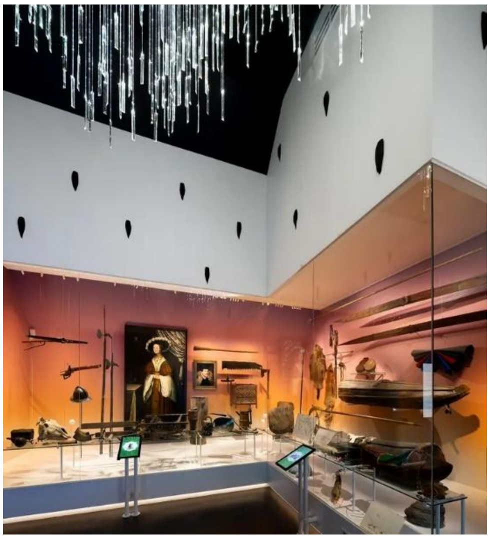


Figure 6. A display featuring various objects from the 16th century.

This limited visibility renders childhood largely absent from the representation of this period, which focuses predominantly on adult experiences rather than children as participants in 16th-century society.

Childhood through wealth, family and vulnerability in the seventeenth century

The first substantial representations of childhood appear in the 17th-century displays. Figure 7 shows a professionally tailored children's dress made from expensive materials, suggesting that it was primarily accessible to wealthy families.

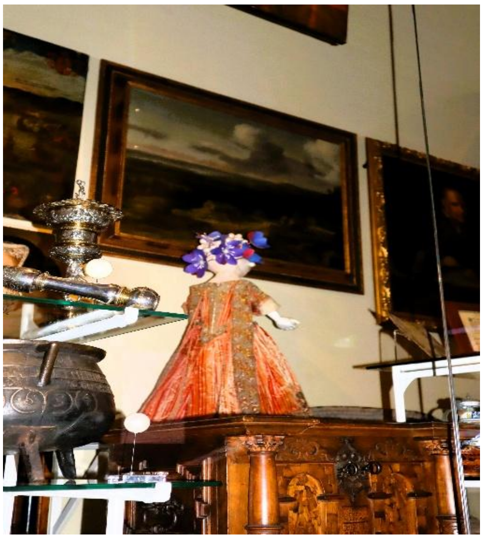


Figure 7. A silk dress from the 17th century. Unknown provenance

Figure 8 depicts a child from a noble family, Siri Oxenstierna , born Wallenberg (1868–1964), who was a Swedish countess of the Wallenberg family.

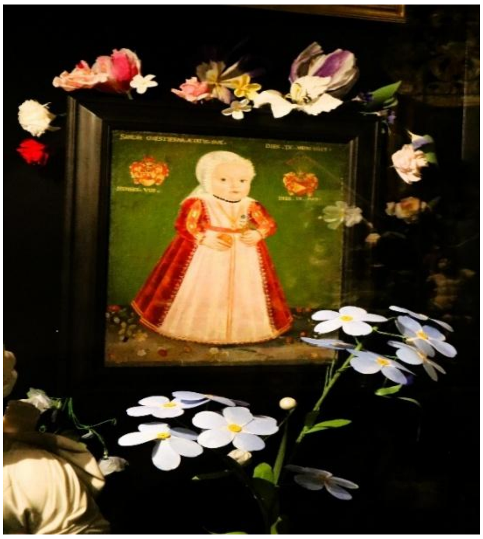


Figure 8. Siri Oxenstierna, born Wallenberg (1868–1964).

Both the dress and the portrait can be understood as expressions of the family's economic and social status. Childhood is represented through material culture associated with wealthy families. Although these objects provide evidence of historical representations of children and childcare practices, little is revealed about the children's everyday lives. The children therefore become known primarily through the objects rather than through their own experiences.

Representations of childhood become more personal in the section on childhood death. Figure 9 shows a display of mourning portraits of named children from noble families, alongside a burial shroud (Figure 10), funeral crowns, wreaths and other memorial objects.

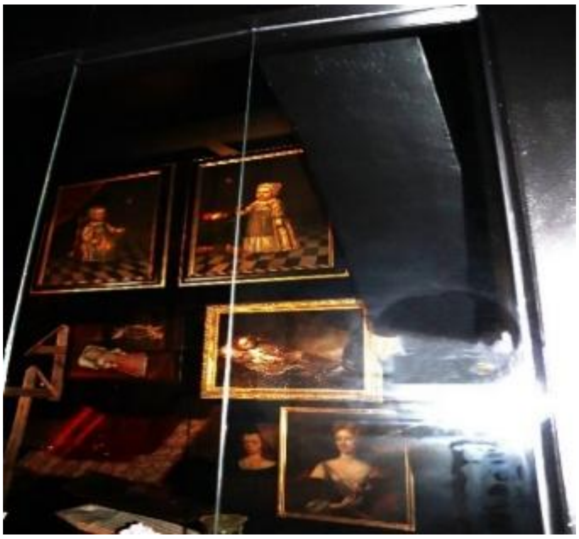


Figure 9. Display with portraits of deceased children from the 17th century.

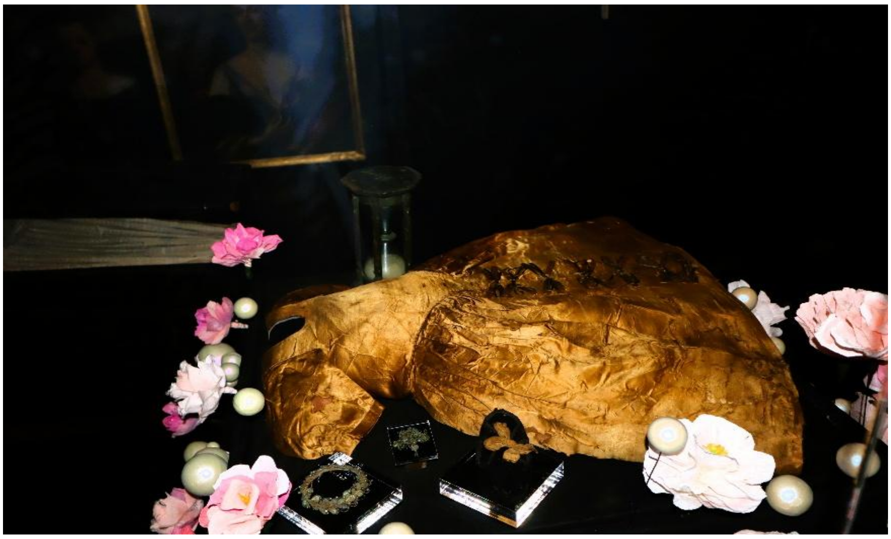


Figure 10. A 17th-century dress made of silk satin, featuring puff sleeves, ribbons, and pleated details, used as a burial shroud.

Although these objects are associated with children and childhood, they primarily represent loss and family remembrance rather than childhood itself. Children are therefore represented as vulnerable individuals through narratives of grief, dependence, mortality and parental affection rather than through their own activities or identities.

Childhood through material culture and social status in the eighteenth-century

Representations of childhood in the 18th-century section continue to focus on material culture and privileged family life, with one exception. A film depicting working children (Figure 11) presents a named child describing his everyday life, wishes and concerns. The accompanying text provides biographical details, including his work and admission to the orphanage; Stora Barnhuset in Stockholm at age six.

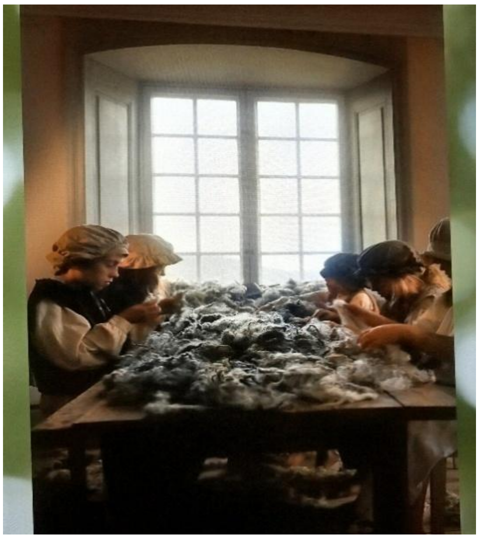


Figure 11. Film footage of working children.

The film presents children through a different social category than those represented in the 16th- and 17th-century sections, drawing attention to social vulnerability and the institutionalisation of childhood. The boy's narration can be understood as an attempt to give a child a voice in history by foregrounding his experiences rather than relying solely on adult or institutional accounts. However, the voice is not the child's actual voice or a direct historical account, but a representation constructed by *Nordic Life*. Although it creates an impression of access to the child's perspective, the narrative remains mediated through adult interpretations of historical childhood. This illustrates the complexities of representing children's voices in historical exhibitions.

As in earlier sections, children and childhood are predominantly represented through objects associated with affluent social groups. This portray is part of the exhibition theme

“The Home: A New Way of Living”, which explores changing ideas of domestic life, housing and how wealthy people lived in the 18th century, see Figure 12.

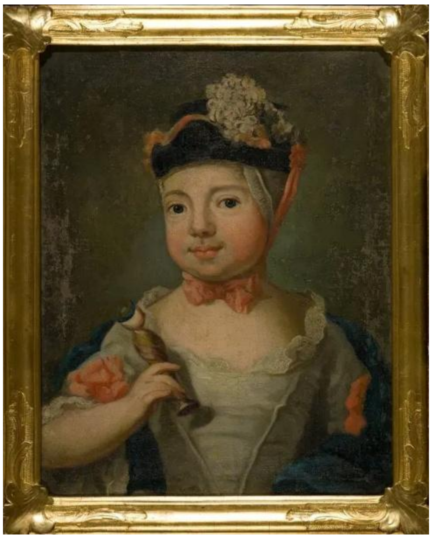


Figure 12. Nordiska museet (2026). Child portrait from the 18th century. Unknown child. Available at: Nordiska museet website (Accessed: 7 August 2026).

Several objects are linked to named children, yet the accompanying information often prioritises broader historical contexts over individual childhood experiences. For example, an infant shirt, which is part of the exhibition theme “The Home: mothers, children, and family life in the 18th-century section, is primarily discussed in relation to infant mortality rather than the child who wore it, see Figure 13.

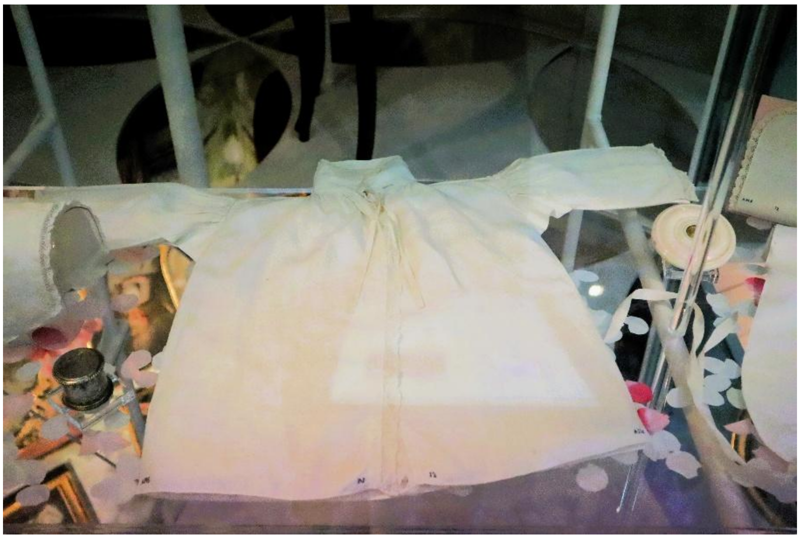


Figure 13. Embroidered linen shirt.

A dollhouse is presented mainly through its ownership and provenance rather than through children's play, see Figure 14.

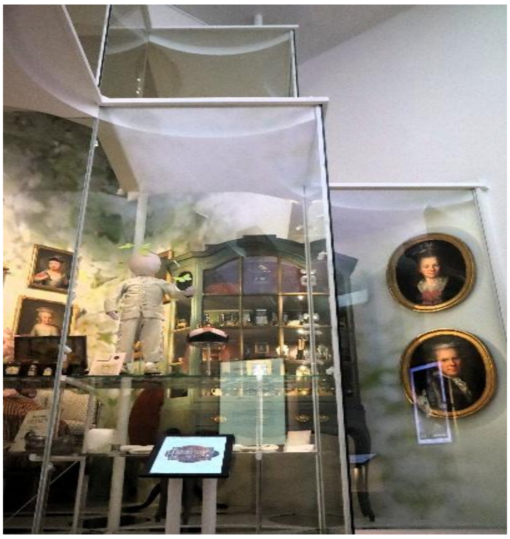


Figure 14. Display featuring objects from the 18th century, including a dollhouse, back against the wall.

These artefacts represent children’s place within family life while reflecting social position, economic resources and ideals of respectability. Portraits of children in fashionable, adult-style clothing present childhood through family values and aspirations rather than children’s own experiences or perspectives. Childhood is therefore constructed as an aspect of elite family life, associated with privilege, protection and material wealth. The exhibition thus provides a selective representation of historical childhood shaped by social class, while childhoods marked by poverty, labour and social vulnerability remain largely absent.

Still limited representations in the nineteenth century

The 19th-century displays include objects associated with childhood, yet children remain relatively marginal within the exhibition narrative. Some objects, such as a doll and a rabbit (Figure 15), are presented not as children’s objects but as decorative items or products intended for tourists.

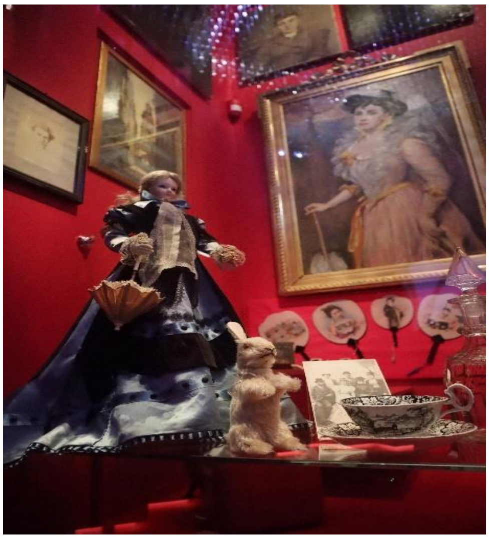


Figure 15. A doll and a rabbit as window decorations at a café in the 19th century.

As in the previous sections of the exhibition, children and childhood are mainly represented through portraits (Figures 16 –17).

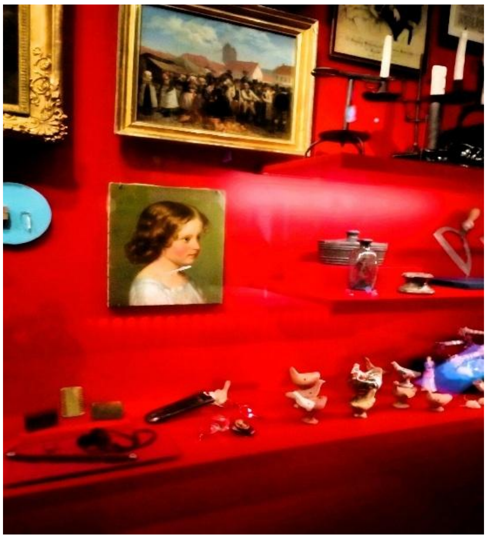


Figure 16. Portrait of an unidentified girl, late 19th century.

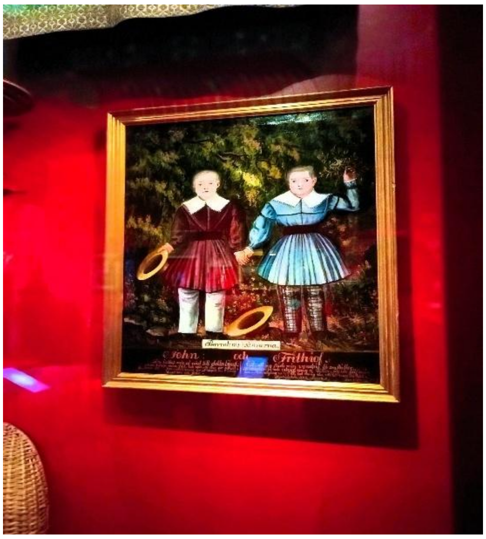


Figure 17. Oil painting of two boys, dated 1841, Sweden.

The large number of objects in the 19th-century section provides relatively little insight into childhood. Many cannot be directly related to children or their everyday lives, while even those explicitly associated with childhood offer limited insight into children's experiences, practices or perspectives. Instead, childhood is primarily represented through adult-produced interpretations.

There are, however, a few exceptions. The section which introduces representations of Sámi artefacts, including a digital film in which a Sámi boy describes his experiences of reindeer herding and living with a host family. A historical photograph also identifies another Sámi child by name and place of origin, while accompanying text provides insight into the child's family life (Figures 18–19).

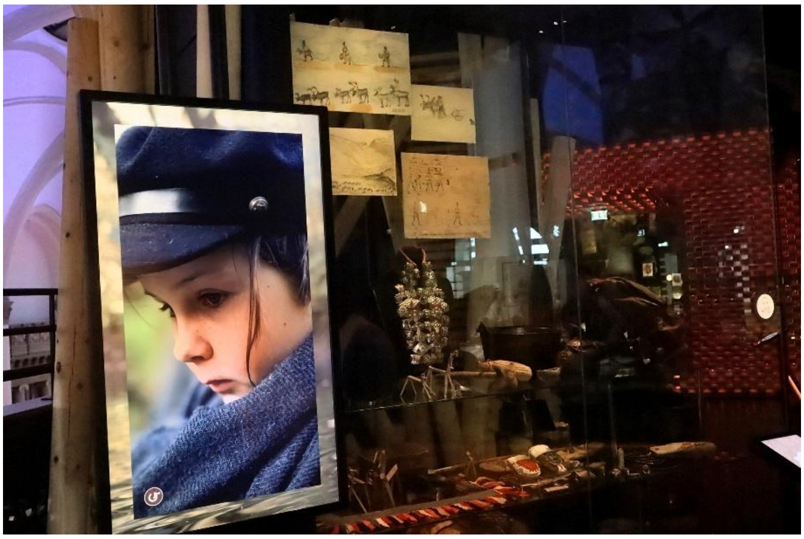


Figure 18. A display featuring Sámi objects, with a screen in front showing a film about a Sámi child.

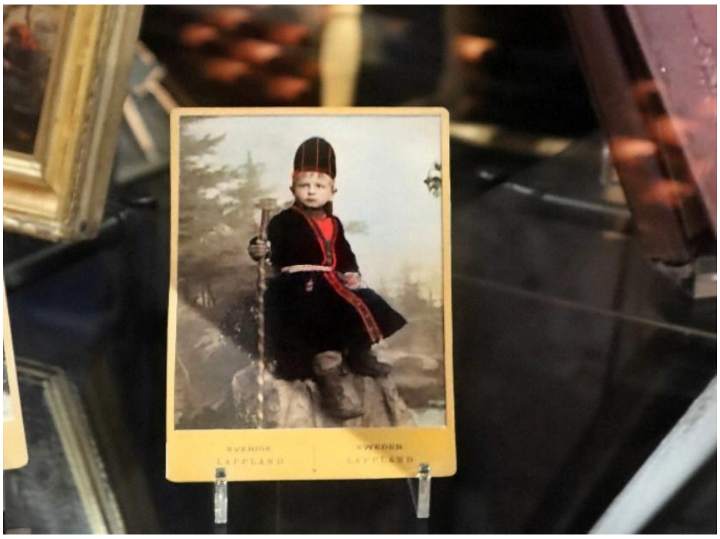


Figure 19. A photograph of a Sámi child.

These examples differ from earlier displays by presenting children with identifiable identities and cultural backgrounds. However, Sámi children are still represented primarily through broader narratives of Indigenous culture and heritage rather than everyday childhood experiences. Although this increases their visibility as individuals, their perspectives remain largely absent.

Childhood, social development, and youth culture in the twentieth century

Representations of children and childhood become considerably more visible in the 20th-century section of *Nordic Life*. Compared with earlier periods, visitors encounter a wider range of childhood objects, including clothing, toys, books, photographs, school-related materials and objects associated with youth culture.

Figure 20 shows a schoolbook used by a child, with the girl's name written in the book. The display text on Roma people in Sweden and their historical situation provides the broader context through which the book and its owner can be identified as belonging to a Roma girl.

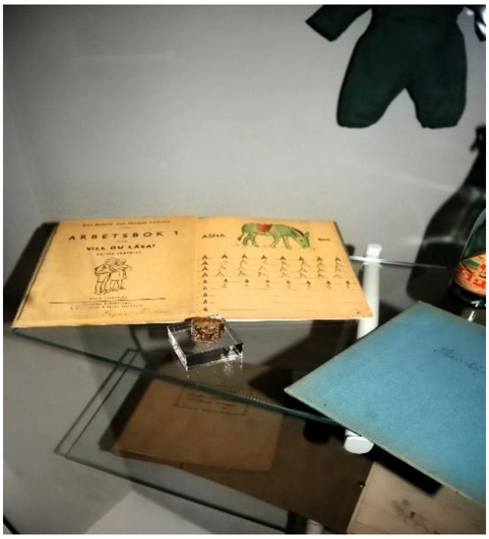


Figure 20. A children's textbook from the 20th century.

No documentation written by the girl herself is presented in the exhibition. Instead, the accompanying text presents a narrative about Roma children's right to education, told by a named person whose age cannot be determined. From a Childhood Studies perspective, this raises questions about children's voices and representation. Although the book provides a material trace of the girl's presence, her perspective is absent from the exhibition and her experience is mediated through others.

During this period, toys made specifically for children became increasingly common. The exhibition mainly features mass-produced toys (Figures 21–22), presented in terms of cultural significance, consumption and popularity. The children who used them remain largely invisible.

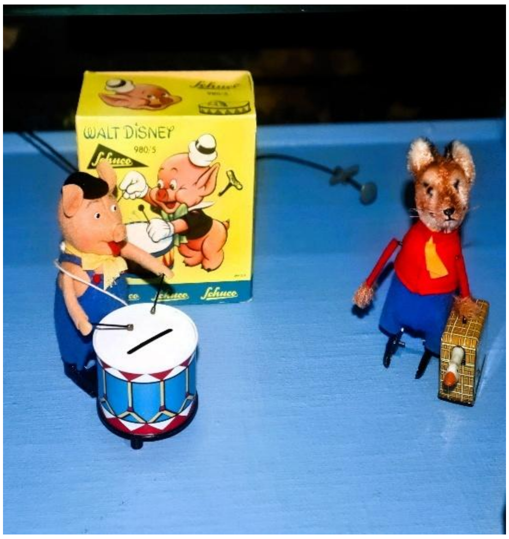


Figure 21. Factory-made toys from the 20th century.

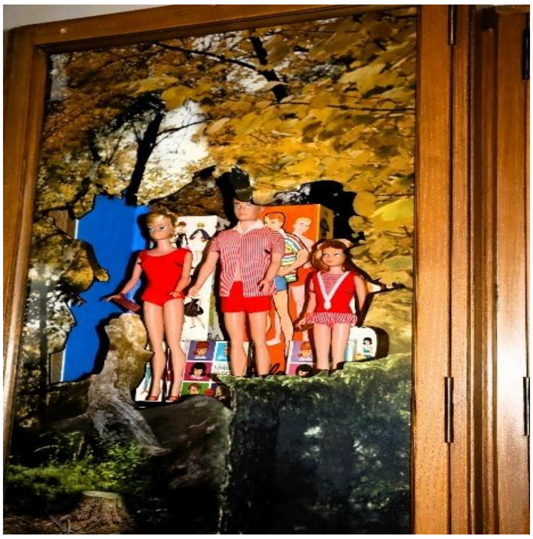


Figure 22. Barbie dolls from the late 60s.

Some objects are visually associated with childhood but have no direct connection to children. A dollhouse featured in the 20th-century section under the theme “The Nuclear Family in Sweden’s Welfare State,” offering a glimpse into family life, domestic ideals and everyday life in the Swedish home, as shown in Figure 23. Although it appears to be a toy intended for children, it was built by the Nordic Museum specifically for the exhibition.

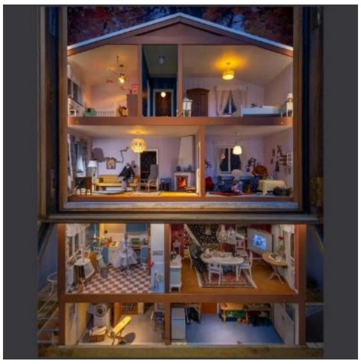


Figure 23. A dollhouse. Available at: Nordiska Museet website (Accessed: 28 August 2026).

From a Childhood Studies perspective, Figures 15 and 23 challenge assumptions about what constitutes an object representing children and childhood. Although the dollhouse resembles a children’s toy, it was created by the Nordic Museum to represent post-war everyday life, while the doll and rabbit in Figure 15 were used as shop-window decorations. These examples demonstrate that an object’s visual association with childhood does not necessarily reflect its function or historical connection to children.

Although this section contains more objects associated with children and childhood, making childhood more visible, these objects primarily illustrate broader social change rather than children's own experiences. As Figure 24 shows, toys, schoolbooks and photographs of children form part of a wider historical narrative.

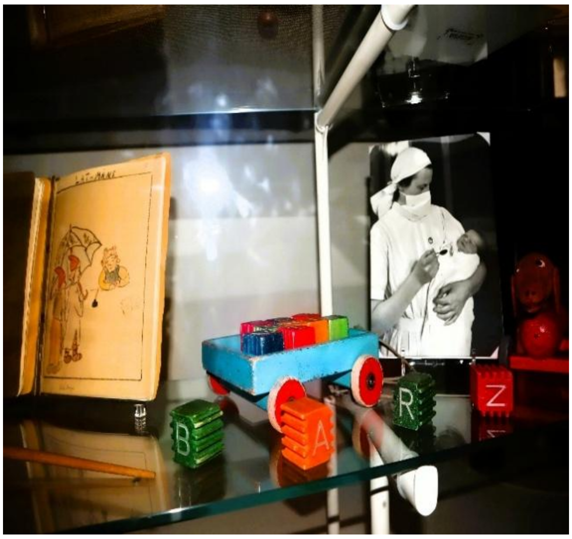


Figure 24. A photograph of an infant, an educational toy, and a textbook from the 20th century.

This pattern is particularly evident in the section on architect Lena Larsson. Photographs and moving images show children in domestic environments (Figure 25), but the emphasis is on changing housing and family living conditions rather than children's own experiences. The children illustrate broader ideals of home and welfare, while their perspectives remain largely absent.

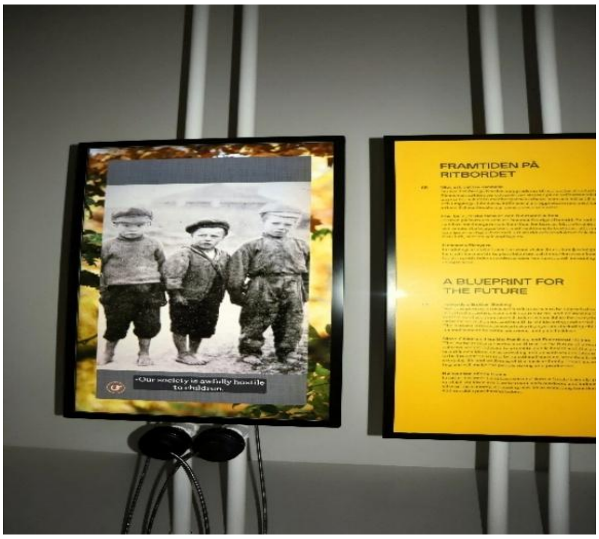

»Our society is awfully hostile to children.
FRAMTIDEN PÅ RITBORDET
A BLUEPRINT FOR THE FUTURE

Figure 25. Film footage and photographs of unidentified children.

The exhibition also represents youth culture through fashion, books, toys, music and consumer products. Figures 26 and 27 offering a glimpse into children’s everyday leisure and social lives.

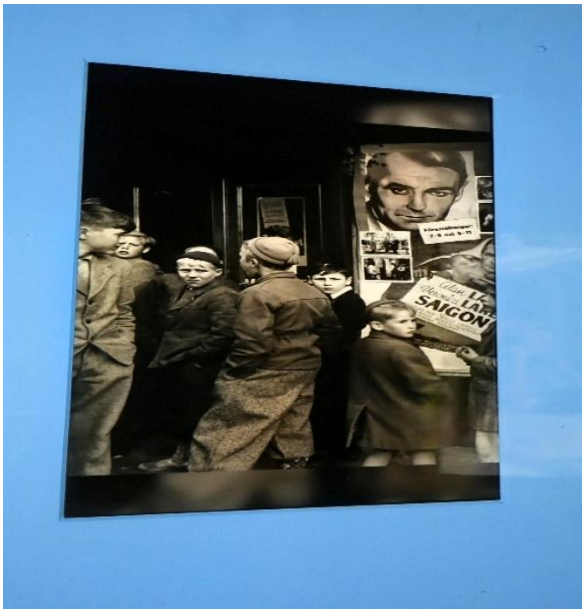


Figure 26. Film footage and photographs of unidentified adolescents during the mid-20-th century.

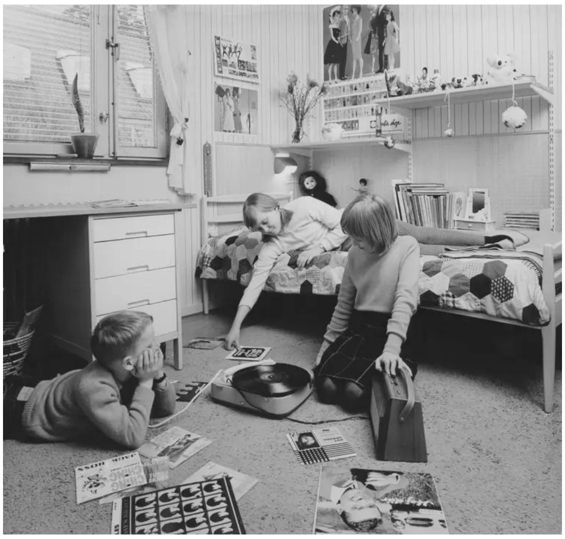


Figure 27. Photograph of adolescents playing music.

These photographs making children´s participation in social and cultural life visible.

Compared with earlier periods, the 20th-century displays offer a broader and more varied representation of childhood. Nevertheless, children still appear mainly as participants in wider societal developments rather than as historical actors whose perspectives shape the exhibition narrative.

Increasing visibility of individual childhood experiences

The late 20th- and 21th-century displays move closer to children's everyday experiences by presenting identifiable children, their preferences and memories. One display includes clothing and personal belongings associated with a child, see Figure 28. The accompanying text gives the child a voice by describing how her mother selected some of her clothing, while she preferred jeans, a T-shirt and wooden shoes. This introduces the child's own preferences and highlights everyday negotiation between parent and child.

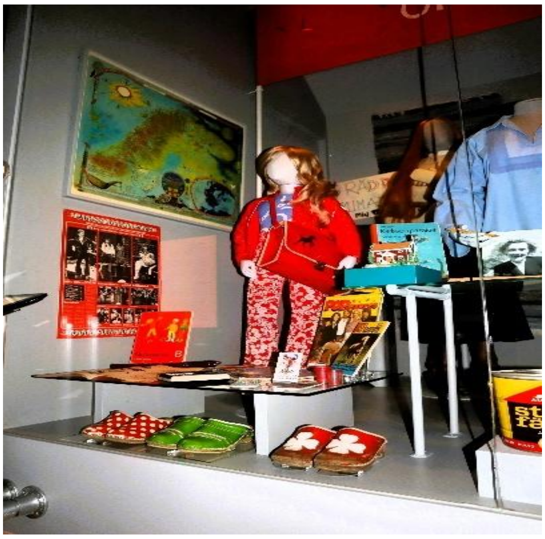


Figure 28. Clothes and shoes belonging to the child named Maria.

This display offers a more individualised representation of childhood than earlier sections, but representations of contemporary childhood remain limited.

The 21th-century section contains relatively few objects associated with childhood, which occupy a less prominent position in the exhibition. One notable exception is a textile carrot figure accompanied by a girl's story about playing Eurovision with her mother and stuffed animals (Figure 29).

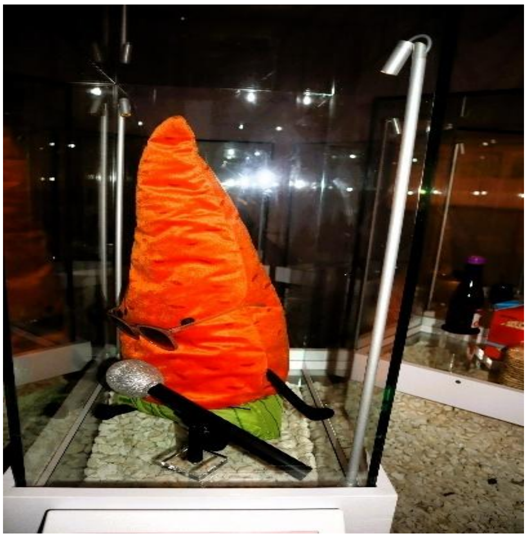


Figure 29. A Textile carrot holding a microphone.

Unlike many earlier representations, this narrative centres on imagination, play and everyday family interaction, presenting childhood as an ordinary lived experience rather than as part of a broader historical narrative. 21th-century section is therefore one of the clearest representations of a child's perspective at *Nordic Life*. However, such representations remain uncommon. The exhibition concludes with images of significant moments in Swedish history and texts addressing changing family structures, including same-sex and independent parenthood (Figure 30).

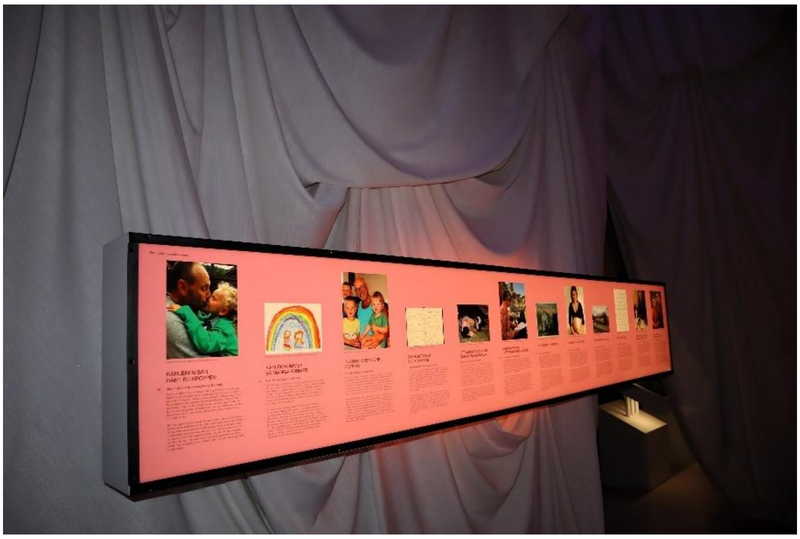


Figure 30. Pictures representing different family structures.

Children appear in these representations primarily as part of narratives about family diversity and social change rather than as subjects of childhood itself. The final interactive installation similarly features ambiguous animated figures that may represent children see Figure 3.

Together, these displays reinforce the exhibition’s tendency to situate children within broader social narratives rather than present childhood as an independent historical experience.

Summary

The analysis demonstrates that Swedish children and childhoods are unevenly represented throughout *Nordic Life*. Given the exhibitions explicitly stated Nordic focus, one might expect representations spanning different Nordic countries and reflecting diverse historical, social and cultural contexts. In the material examined here, however, representations primarily concern Swedish children and childhoods. Although the exhibition spans approximately five centuries, childhood becomes more visible from the 17th century onwards, mainly through material culture and family-related narratives. These provide evidence of children’s historical presence but reveal only selected aspects of childhood.

Across the exhibition, childhood is largely constructed through families, adults and wider social structures, reflecting predominantly adult perspectives. Childhoods associated with wealthy families, material security and normative social structures are more visible, while experiences shaped by poverty, labour and social vulnerability remain largely absent. Although later sections occasionally introduce children’s memories and stories, these remain exceptions. Taken together, the material points to a selective portrayal of childhood, while the exhibition’s broader Nordic framing suggests a wider geographical scope than is evident in the Swedish material examined here.

Constructing childhood through objects, texts and exhibition design

The analysis in this section examines how material choices, textual framing, visual arrangements and spatial organisation shape narratives about children and childhood.

Objects as narrative devices

Material objects play an important role in shaping narratives of childhood, but their meanings are not fixed. Through selection, placement and contextualisation, the museum constructs particular interpretations of the past. Throughout *Nordic Life*, childhood is primarily represented through clothing, toys, books, photographs and school-related objects.

The dominance of these categories contributes to a representation of children mainly as recipients of care and consumption rather than as active participants in creating and shaping material culture. Objects produced, modified or creatively used by children are largely absent.

Object selection also shapes whose childhood becomes historically visible. Many objects are associated with wealthy households, such as the expensive dress in Figure 7.

Similarly, Figure 31 represents childhood through winter activities, showing a child mannequin in winter clothing alongside downhill skis, an activity that potentially was relatively expensive and perhaps less accessible to working-class children.

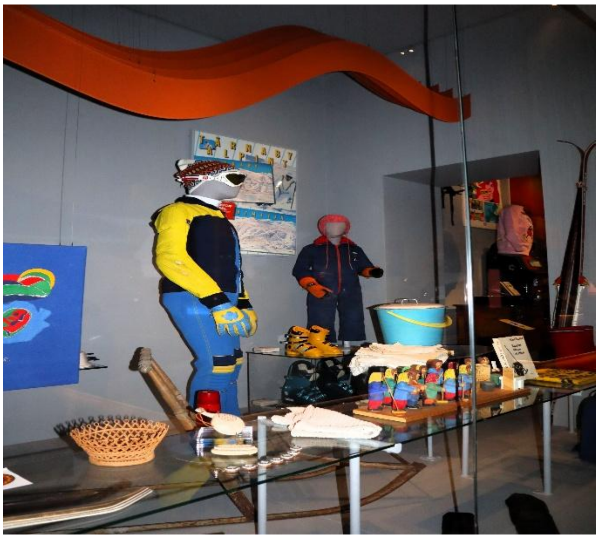


Figure 31. Twentieth-century objects associated with winter activities.

Taken together, these displays present a relatively privileged image of childhood. The emphasis on consumption and wealth limits the visibility of children’s agency and working-class childhoods, while experiences shaped by poverty, labour or limited resources receive no attention at all. *Nordic Life* therefore risks reproducing a class-based normative image of childhood.

Object placement also contributes to meaning-making. Childhood objects are rarely displayed independently but incorporated into broader themes such as family life, education, housing and cultural traditions. For example, Figure 32 places toys and children’s clothing within a display on population policy.

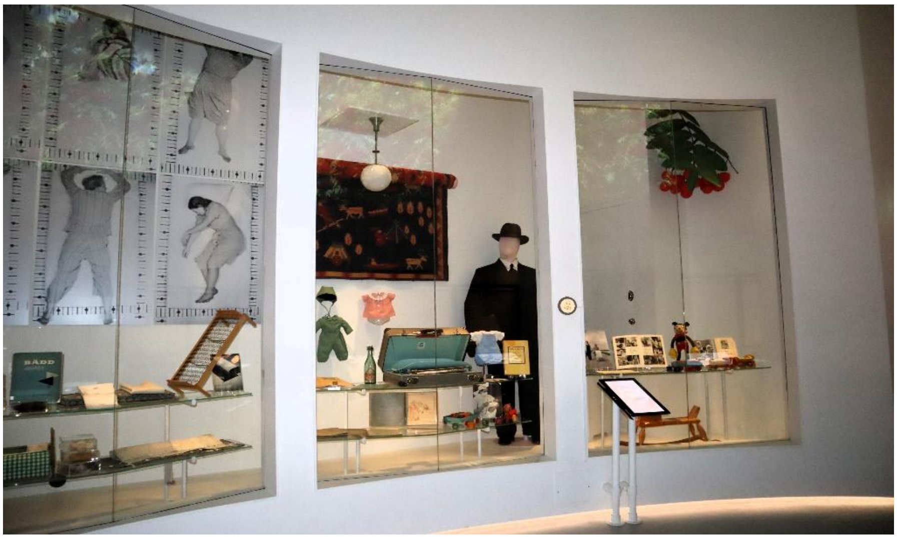


Figure 32. A display with different objects from the mid-20th century.

Another example is in the 17th-century section under the theme highlighting the role of craftsmanship and guilds in urban life in which the exhibition uses a child's dress to represent guilds and crafts within a broader narrative of 17th-century urban life, see Figure 33.

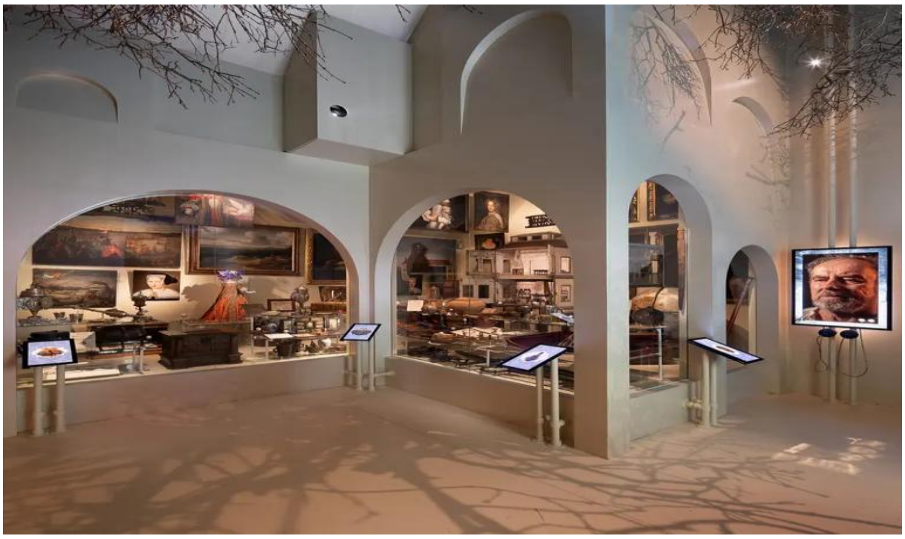


Figure 33. Display featuring objects from the 17th century. Available at: Nordiska museet website (Accessed: 11 August 2026).

These examples show that children and childhood are presented through broader social and historical themes rather than as subjects in their own right. Children's objects therefore function primarily as narrative devices, their meaning is shaped by the historical contexts and curatorial choices in which they are presented, rather than by the objects themselves.

Texts as interpretive frameworks

Interpretive texts are central to the construction of childhood narratives in *Nordic Life*, guiding visitors towards particular understandings of objects. Throughout the exhibition, objects associated with children are primarily interpreted through broader themes such as housing, education, family life, welfare and social change rather than children's own experiences. For example, Figure 34 links a child's romper to 20h-century social policy concerning children's health and upbringing, while the text accompanying Figure 34 emphasis society's role in children's early development and education.

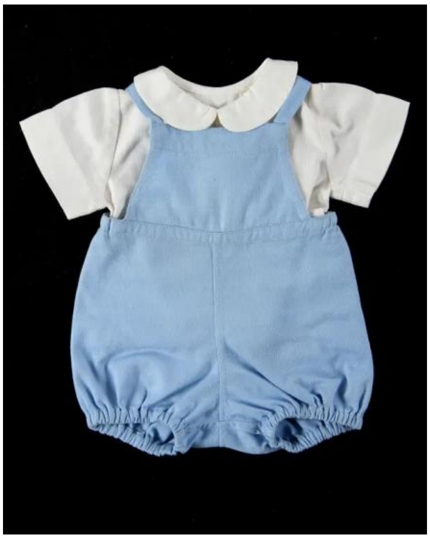


Figure 34. 1940s play trousers. Available at: Nordiska museet website (Accessed: 12 August 2026).

These broader contexts are historically relevant, but they frame childhood primarily through adult institutions and societal developments. Rather than foregrounding children's perspectives, the interpretive texts position them within adult narratives of family life, nation-building, social progress and cultural heritage.

A small number of displays introduce children's stories, but these remain mediated through museum interpretation. The textile figure accompanied by a girl's story about playing Eurovision with her mother and stuffed animals (Figure 29), offers a rare insight into a child's everyday experiences of imagination, play and family interaction. However, the story reaches visitors through the museum's selection and presentation rather than through the child's voice directly.

A similar pattern appears in displays concerning Sámi childhood. Interactive screens (Figure 18) and text accompanying a photograph of a Sámi child (Figure 19) present named children and aspects of everyday life, cultural traditions and reindeer herding. While these provide more personal representations, children’s experiences remain embedded within broader narratives of Indigenous identity and cultural heritage.

Interpretive texts therefore do more than explain objects, they connect them to particular historical understandings of childhood. Through the selection and framing of stories and contexts, the museum privileges some interpretations over others. Childhood consequently emerges primarily through adult perspectives.

Exhibition design as a framework for constructing childhood narratives

Exhibition design shapes the spatial and sensory contexts in which children and childhood are represented. Figure 31, for example, places children’s winter clothing alongside objects not specifically associated with childhood, positioning childhood within a broader narrative of winter activities.

Lighting, sound, colour, and digital media further shape visitors’ interpretations. In the 19th-century section, under the theme nature, which focuses, inter alia, on Sámi culture, dim lighting, atmospheric sound, and projections of northern landscapes create an immersive environment. As shown in Figure 35, these elements connect representations of children with nature, cultural continuity and Indigenous identity. Together with objects and texts, exhibition design therefore frames how childhood is understood within broader historical and cultural narratives.

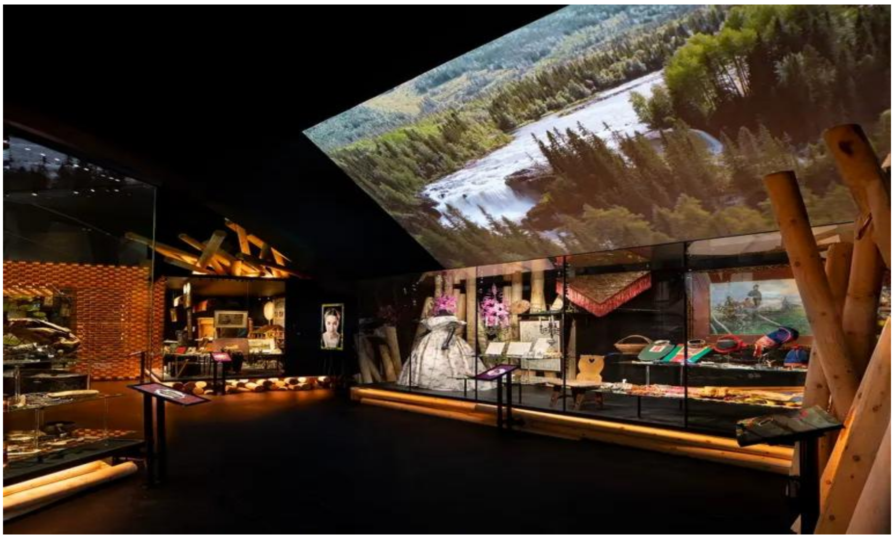


Figure 35. A display featuring Sámi objects with a big screen with forests and nature above. Available at: Nordiska museet website (Accessed: 12 August 2026).

Rather than allowing visitors to interpret objects independently, these design choices encourage particular emotional and cultural readings.

A similar process occurs in the 17th section under the theme virtue and death, where dim lighting and a sombre atmosphere frame portraits, funeral objects and children's clothing within narratives of grief and remembrance, see Figure 36.

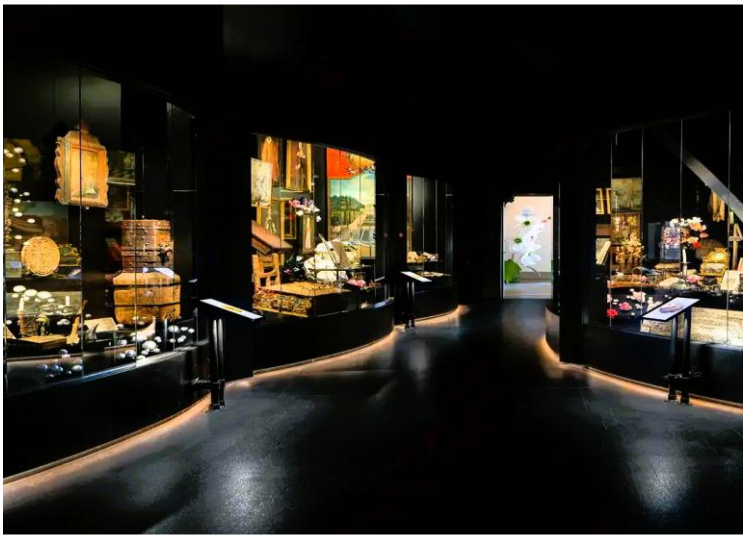


Figure 36. Display featuring portraits and funeral items of deceased children. Available at: Nordiska museet website (Accessed: 11 August 2026).

Although these objects could potentially communicate multiple aspects of childhood, the exhibition design encourages visitors to interpret them primarily as symbols of vulnerability, mortality and family attachment. Meaning is therefore produced not only through the objects themselves but also through the emotional environments in which they are displayed.
These examples demonstrate that exhibition design functions as an interpretive tool rather than a neutral background. Spatial organisation, lighting, sound and digital media actively shape visitors' understandings of childhood by directing attention towards particular themes and emotional responses. Consequently, childhood is experienced as a curated narrative that reflects the museum's interpretive choices rather than an objective presentation of historical reality.

Constructing narratives of childhood through exhibition practices

The analysis demonstrates that narratives of childhood in *Nordic Life* are produced through the interaction of exhibition design, material objects and interpretive texts. These practices work together to shape how visitors understand childhood, design frames the environments in which objects are encountered, object selection determines which childhoods become visible and interpretive texts guide their interpretation.

Through repeated curatorial choices, childhood is framed within particular social and cultural contexts, while spatial and sensory design reinforces these interpretations. At the same time, processes of selection and exclusion shape which childhoods are represented. The emphasis on objects associated with wealthy households contributes to a representation of childhood centred on material security and privilege. In contrast, childhoods shaped by poverty, child labour and other forms of social vulnerability are largely absent from the exhibition, with only a few exceptions. Children's agency is similarly limited, as children are primarily represented through adult-collected objects, family memories, and museum interpretations rather than through their own perspectives and experiences.

These patterns demonstrate that *Nordic Life* does not present a comprehensive history of childhood, but a selective narrative shaped by curatorial priorities. What is included, how it is framed, and what remains absent influence which childhoods become visible and what visitors come to recognise as childhood.

Summary

Overall, the analysis shows that childhood in *Nordic Life* is actively constructed through the interaction of objects, interpretive texts and exhibition design. These practices shape what becomes visible, how it is interpreted and how visitors are positioned in relation to representations of childhood. Object selection and placement, textual framing and spatial and sensory design therefore work together rather than independently.

The analysis also shows that these practices shape the representation of childhood by determining what is included, how it is presented, and what is left out. While they make aspects of childhood visible, they simultaneously limit the visibility of other experiences and perspectives. Childhood is therefore not simply presented through the material on display but constructed through curatorial and exhibition practices that influence whose experiences become part of the narrative and how childhood is understood.

Absences and marginalisation in the exhibition Nordic Life

The analysis demonstrates that children's perspectives are only partially included in *Nordic Life*. Childhood is predominantly interpreted through adult perspectives, leaving children's own voices in a marginal position rather than allowing them to shape the narrative in their own right.

This limited presence should also be understood within broader patterns of representation and absence. Some minority and marginalised groups are represented through adult, institutional or collective narratives, while others receive little or no representation.The issue therefore extends beyond the distinction between children's and adults' perspectives and concerns whose experiences and perspectives are selected, made visible or are excluded.

The absence of children's own voices

A central finding is that children's own voices are largely absent throughout the exhibition. Although many displays contain objects associated with childhood, these seldom communicate how children experienced or understood their lives. Instead, museum texts interpret their historical significance primarily through adult perspectives.

This is particularly evident in the earlier historical sections. During the 17th and 18th centuries, childhood is represented mainly through objects from wealthy families and narratives concerning family life, inheritance and remembrance. Portraits, funeral objects and children's clothing demonstrate children's presence in these historical contexts, but provide limited insight into their feelings, relationships or everyday experiences. Children thus become visible as historical subjects while remaining largely silent as historical voices. Even when individual children are identified by name, their experiences are generally mediated through adult interpretations, illustrating that the presence of children in an exhibition does not necessarily mean that their perspectives are represented.

An example can be found in the 19th-century section, under the theme “Flight, Resistance and Diplomacy”. A photograph from Mölle, dated 1944 (see Figure 37), shows a woman and two children. However, the accompanying text focuses primarily on the mother and provides no information about the children's names, living conditions or experiences during the Second World War. Although the children are physically present in the photograph, their perspectives and experiences therefore remain largely absent from the exhibition's narrative.

Figure 37. Photography of two children with their mother. Available at: Nordiska museet website (Accessed: 12 August 2026).

Unequal representation of childhoods

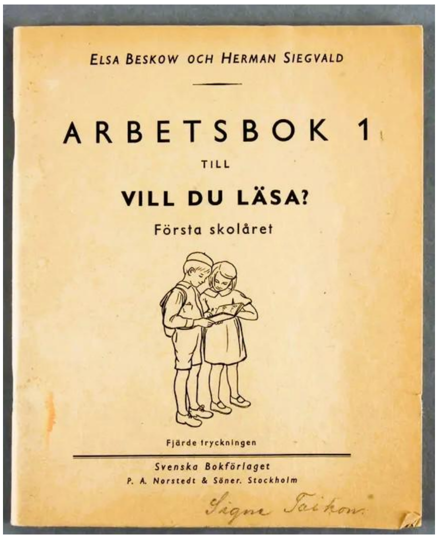
The analysis reveals an unequal representation of childhoods in *Nordic Life,* where some experiences are more visible than others.

The analysis identified an absence of distinct Nordic childhood perspectives in the exhibition. Despite its Nordic framing, representations of childhood were predominantly situated within a Swedish context. Childhood experiences and everyday lives from across the Nordic region were not visibly represented as distinct perspectives.

This selectivity is also evident in relation to ethnic and cultural diversity. During the observations, no distinct representations of the experiences and histories of national minorities, including Jews, Tornedalians, Tatars, Inuit and Faroese, were identified. The Sámi are particularly significant in a Nordic context, as they are recognised as an Indigenous people across Sweden, Norway and Finland, yet Indigenous perspectives and experiences appear to have limited representation. Other minority groups, including Jews, Roma, Swedish Finns and Tornedalians, are similarly difficult to identify.

The exhibition includes representations of Sámi and Roma people, but these do not necessarily provide access to individuals' own perspectives. Instead, individuals are presented through broader social, cultural or institutional narratives. The representation of Roma children illustrates this pattern. Although the 20th-century section, under the theme "Population Policy," includes a textbook once owned by a Roma child (Figure 38), the object is not contextualised in relation to the child's everyday life or experiences in early 20th-century Sweden. Instead, it is situated within a broader narrative about the social situation of

Roma people. The child is therefore made visible through the object, while the child's individual perspective remains difficult to access.



ELSA BESKOW OCH HERMAN SIEGVALD

ARBETSBOK 1
TILL
VILL DU LÄSA?
Första skolåret

Fjärde tryckningen

Svenska Bokförlaget
P. A. Norstedt & Söner. Stockholm

Signe Taikon

Figure 38. Schoolbook. Available at: Nordiska museet website (Accessed: 12 August 2026).

A similar pattern can be observed in the representation of Sámi children. Their presence contributes to the exhibition's account of Swedish cultural and social history, but their representation is largely connected to collective cultural practices and material heritage. This may make Sámi childhood visible as a cultural category without providing insight into the diversity of individual children's experiences or perspectives.

Difficult or sensitive historical experiences are similarly less visible or absent. For example, the experiences of Jewish children who came to Sweden during the Second World War are not represented in the material examined, despite their relevance to the history of childhood in Sweden. Such absences affect not only which children become visible, but also which childhood experiences can be communicated through the exhibition.

These patterns suggest that the marginalisation of children's perspectives forms part of a broader pattern of selective representation. The issue is not simply that children are denied a voice while adults or minority groups are consistently given one. Adults and members of minority or marginalised groups may also be represented through objects, family histories, institutional interpretations or broader collective narratives rather than through perspectives directly attributable to themselves. However, these forms of marginalisation should not be treated as identical. Children's perspectives are shaped by the particular power relations associated with childhood and by the historical difficulties of accessing children's voices, while the representation of ethnic and social groups may involve other processes, such as categorisation, homogenisation or the dominance of majority narratives.

The analysis therefore points to a broader question of whose experiences and perspectives are made visible, whose remain marginalised or absent, and how these processes shape the representation of childhood in *Nordic Life*.

Marginalisation and absence

The analysis demonstrates that the representation of children and childhood in *Nordic Life* is uneven. Children and childhood are highly visible in some displays, while other displays provide little or no representation. Where children are represented, their experiences and perspectives are generally mediated through adult and institutional interpretations rather than presented directly in the children's own voices.

The distinction between representing children and representing children's perspectives is therefore central. The presence of children as historical subjects does not necessarily provide access to their perspectives, experiences, or voices. Some displays include children's memories, preferences or everyday experiences, but these are presented through the museum's selection, interpretation and contextualisation. Children may therefore be visible within the exhibition while their perspectives remain mediated and limited in shaping the narrative.

This is significant because the issue concerns not only whether children are represented, but which childhoods become visible and whose perspectives are given narrative authority. The uneven representation of childhood means that some experiences remain less visible or absent, while the perspectives of represented children are consistently shaped through adult and institutional frameworks. This highlights the distinction between visibility, perspective, agency and demonstrates how the exhibition constructs particular understandings of childhood through selective representation and mediation.

Summary

The analysis demonstrates that *Nordic Life* constructs childhood through a selective set of perspectives, with children's experiences largely mediated through adult and institutional narratives. From a Childhood Studies perspective, this highlights how social, historical, cultural, and material conditions shape representations of childhood. The exhibition reveals unequal representation, with some experiences receiving limited attention or remaining absent altogether. This selectivity also shapes how "Nordic" childhood is constructed. The limited presence of ethnic minorities and Indigenous perspectives suggests a relatively narrow, Sweden-centred representation. This is not simply a question of which groups or countries are included, but whose experiences are positioned as representative of Nordic childhood. The absence of both minority groups and representations from across the Nordic countries is particularly significant given the region's transnational and cultural diversity. Overall, the findings point to a tension between the exhibition's broad Nordic framing and the narrower range of childhoods through which it is represented.

Conclusions

This thesis has examined how children and childhood are represented in *Nordic Life* at Nordiska museet, with particular attention to how exhibition design, objects, texts and other forms of mediation construct narratives about childhood, and to the extent to which children's perspectives are included, marginalised or absent. Drawing on Childhood Studies, the study understands childhood as socially and culturally constructed and shaped by historical and social contexts (James & Prout 2015:3–4). A child perspective is similarly understood as an analytical orientation that considers children's positions, conditions and experiences within broader social contexts (Halldén 2003:14–17).

Selective representations of childhood

Regarding the first research question, children and childhood are represented throughout *Nordic Life*, but not equally across historical periods or different experiences of childhood. Childhoods associated with family life, normative social structures and relatively privileged circumstances are more visible, while experiences shaped by poverty, child labour, disability, migration and other forms of social marginalisation receive less attention or are absent. Childhood is frequently represented through play, family and learning. While these themes establish childhood as part of social and cultural history, they may also contribute to a generalised understanding of childhood.

This finding is significant because childhood cannot be understood as a universal or homogeneous experience. Children's lives are shaped by particular historical, social, cultural, economic and material circumstances. The findings are consistent with Roberts' (2006:154, 161) and Brookshaw's (2009:366, 379–381) observations that museum representations of children may privilege nostalgia and innocence. The relevance of these observations to *Nordic Life* is not that the exhibition simply reproduces such representations, but that similar patterns can be identified in the ways childhood is incorporated into a broader historical narrative. The exhibition makes childhood visible while giving greater attention to some experiences than others.

The distinction between visibility and representation is central to the findings. A child may be visible through an object without the child's social position, experiences or agency becoming equally visible. The presence of children within an exhibition should therefore not automatically be understood as evidence of representational plurality.

Exhibition mediation and the construction of meaning

Regarding the second research question, the findings demonstrate that exhibition design, objects and texts work together to construct narratives about children and childhood. Child-related objects at *Nordic Life* are generally interpreted within broader narratives concerning family, education, welfare, social change and cultural heritage. Their meanings are consequently not determined by the objects themselves but are produced through processes of selection, contextualisation and presentation.

This supports the broader understanding of museums as institutions that do not merely preserve and communicate historical knowledge but also participate in shaping how the past is selected, interpreted and represented (Hooper-Greenhill 1992:17; 1994:18–19). In *Nordic Life*, the positioning of child-related objects within wider historical narratives contributes to particular understandings of what childhood has meant. The exhibition therefore does not simply present material traces of childhood; it mediates the meanings attached to those traces.

The findings from *Nordic Life* illustrate the importance of distinguishing between the *material culture of childhood* and the *material culture of children*. Objects associated with children may reveal ideas and expectations surrounding childhood without providing direct access to children's own experiences (Brookshaw 2009:365–370). The findings at *Nordic Life* reveal more about adult constructions of childhood than about children's lived realities (Brandow-Faller 2018:22; Patterson & Friend 2021:169). In line with Roberts' (2006:154, 161) findings, the analysis also indicates that *Nordic Life* emphasises nostalgia and innocence. Objects in *Nordic Life* therefore do not simply provide evidence of historical childhood but participate in constructing a particular narrative about it.

Children's voices and historical silence

Regarding the third research question, the analysis shows that a child perspective is present only to a limited extent and is frequently mediated through adult perspectives. Children are visible as subjects within the exhibition, but their own voices, interpretations and agency are less consistently represented. This absence should not, however, be interpreted as evidence that children did not produce historical knowledge or that meaningful histories of childhood cannot be constructed without direct testimony. Rather, it raises a methodological and epistemological question concerning how children's voices are preserved, mediated and represented.

Historical knowledge about children is often mediated through sources produced, collected or preserved by adults and institutions, meaning that children's own interpretations may be fragmentary or difficult to distinguish from later adult interpretations. Gallagher's (2023:397) discussion of historical silences is relevant here, particularly regarding the role of power in determining what is collected, preserved, interpreted and made visible.

From this perspective, the limited presence of direct children's voices in *Nordic Life* cannot necessarily be explained simply by a lack of historical material. It can also be understood in relation to the processes through which knowledge about childhood has historically been produced and mediated. The central question is therefore not only whether children's voices are present, but whose interpretations mediate knowledge about children and whether this mediation is made visible.

The presence of objects associated with children should consequently not automatically be interpreted as evidence of a child perspective. Objects can provide evidence about children's material conditions and everyday environments while still being interpreted primarily from an adult perspective. At the same time, the absence of direct testimony does not prevent museums from constructing meaningful histories of childhood through objects, photographs, documents and other historical traces.

Power and absence

The findings can further be understood through Stuart Hall's concept of representation. Representation is not a neutral reflection of reality but a process through which meaning is produced through culturally shared systems of signs and concepts (Hall 1997:28–29, 61–62). Representation is also connected to power. Hall (1997:259, 261) emphasises that systems of representation influence which meanings, identities and experiences become visible.

In *Nordic Life*, this makes absences analytically significant. What is not represented, or receives less interpretive space, can be as important as what is displayed. Previous research similarly demonstrates that museum representations can privilege certain experiences while marginalising or excluding others (Potinkara 2020:2140; Kalsås 2015:33, 46; Baglo 2019:25–27, 39–40). The analysis indicates that the exhibition's coherent narrative is partly produced through selection, leaving some childhood experiences, perspectives and social positions less visible.

Whose Nordic history?

The question of representation also extends to the broader historical narrative. Although *Nordic Life* presents life and people in the Nordic region across approximately 500 years, the analysis identifies a strong emphasis on Swedish society, culture and people. This matters because representations of childhood are embedded within broader ideas about Nordic society, family, social life, cultural practices and national belonging. The question of whose childhood is represented is therefore connected to whose history is represented. The analysis points to a tension between the exhibition's broader Nordic framing and the prominence of Swedish history.

From visibility to plurality

Taken together, the findings show that *Nordic Life* makes children and childhood visible, particularly through material culture and representations of everyday life. However, visibility does not necessarily mean plurality or the inclusion of children's perspectives. The exhibition places children within a broad historical narrative but does not fully communicate the diversity of childhoods across its approximately 500-year scope. Differences between historical periods are represented, while differences between children within the same period or social context receive less attention. From a Childhood Studies perspective, this is significant because childhood is neither universal nor homogeneous. Children's experiences are shaped by historical and social circumstances, and children can be understood as social actors rather than simply recipients of adult structures (James & Prout 2015:3–4).

The study highlights the importance of distinguishing between the representation of children, childhood, and children's perspectives. These are related but not interchangeable. A museum may display objects associated with children while still relying primarily on adult-produced narratives. A child perspective requires attention to children's positions, conditions, and perspectives within the social contexts represented (Halldén 2003:14–17). The findings therefore highlight the importance of considering not only what an exhibition makes visible, but also whose experiences and interpretations remain absent.

Further research

This study contributes to research on children, childhood and museums by demonstrating how representations of childhood can be examined through the relationship between material culture, exhibition mediation and power. It also highlights the importance of considering absence alongside visibility.

Further research could compare how museums construct childhood across different national and cultural contexts, including how objects, archival documents and oral histories are used when direct children's voices are unavailable or fragmentary. Such research could further examine how adult and institutional mediation shapes representations of children's lives and how historical silences are negotiated.

Limitations

The findings should be understood within the scope of this study. The analysis focuses on one exhibition at one museum and does not claim to represent museum representations of childhood more generally. It examines the exhibition as presented to visitors and does not explore how children themselves interpret or experience it. The absence of children's voices therefore reflects the study's scope rather than children's actual experiences. Despite these limitations, the study shows how childhood is shaped through curatorial selection, mediation, and omission, within broader cultural and historical frameworks.

Declaration of AI-assisted technologies

AI-assisted technologies were used for language-related support during the preparation of this thesis. Grammarly was used for proofreading, grammar and spelling checks and sentence clarity. ChatGPT (OpenAI) was used to critically evaluate Grammarly's language suggestions.

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Appendix A

Structured Observational Protocol

Study: Representation of children and childhood in *Nordic Life*, Nordiska museet

Date of field visit: 21 May 2026

Method: Structured walkthrough observation

Focus: Representation of children and childhood within the exhibition

Purpose of the protocol

The observational protocol is developed from the research questions and analytical themes of the study, used during the walkthrough of the *Nordic Life* exhibition to structure the documentation of exhibition elements relevant to the representation of children and childhood.

The protocol is a complement to fieldnotes and photographs. The protocol function as a guide for systematic observation rather than as a rigid coding scheme, allowing observations that emerged during the walkthrough to also be documented.

Exhibition context and spatial organisation

Observation focus

The overall organisation of the exhibition and the spatial positioning of displays related to children and childhood.

Guiding questions

Where in the exhibition do children and childhood appear?

In which rooms, sections, or thematic contexts are children represented?

How prominent or peripheral are these representations?

Are displays concerning children concentrated in particular areas?

How are objects concerning children positioned in relation to other objects and themes?

Does the spatial organisation connect childhood to particular historical or social themes?

Are there areas where children or childhood might reasonably be expected but are absent?

Fieldnotes

- Location/section:

- Spatial arrangement:
- Prominence/peripherality:
- Connections to surrounding displays:
- Relevant observations:
- Photographic documentation
- Photograph(s) taken: Yes / No
- Photograph reference:
- Purpose of photograph:

Representations of childhood

Observation focus
The meanings and characteristics attributed to childhood through objects, images, texts, and displays.

Guiding questions
What is childhood represented as?

Is childhood presented primarily as a period of play, education, family life, work, vulnerability, development, consumption, or something else?

Is childhood represented as similar across different historical or social contexts?

Are differences in childhood experiences acknowledged?

How are age, gender, class, family, geography, or other social conditions reflected?

What assumptions about childhood are communicated through the exhibition?

Fieldnotes
- Representation of childhood:
- Activities/experiences:
- Social conditions:
- Differences/variations:

- Relevant observations:

Objects and material representations

Observation focus

Objects used to represent children, childhood, children's lives, or experiences of childhood.

Guiding questions

What objects are used to represent children and childhood?

What aspects of children's lives do the objects make visible?

What kinds of activities, experiences, relationships, or identities are represented?

Are children represented directly through objects associated with them, or indirectly through objects selected and interpreted by adults?

How are objects positioned and presented?

Are objects accompanied by contextual information about children and their lives?

What aspects of childhood are not represented through the selected objects?

Fieldnotes

- Object:
- Object type/material:
- Context of display:
- Representation of childhood:
- Relevant historical/social context:
- Presence/absence:
- Relevant observations:
- Photographic documentation
- Photograph(s) taken:
- Photograph reference:
- Purpose of photograph:

Exhibition texts and textual framing

Observation focus

Labels, captions, introductory texts, thematic texts, quotations, and other written material accompanying displays.

Guiding questions

How are children and childhood described in exhibition texts?

What terminology is used to describe children?

Whose perspectives or voices are presented?

Are children’s own words or experiences included?

Are children discussed primarily through adult, family, institutional, or societal perspectives?

How do texts contextualise the objects?

What historical narratives are created or reinforced through the textual framing?

What aspects of childhood are emphasised or omitted?

Fieldnotes

- Text/location:
- Main theme:
- Representation of children/childhood:
- Perspective/voice:
- Relationship to object/display:
- Relevant historical narrative:
- Relevant observations:
- Photographic documentation
- Photograph(s) taken:
- Photograph reference:
- Purpose of photograph:

Adult-centred perspectives

Observation focus

The extent to which children's lives are represented through adult interpretations, categories, and institutional perspectives.

Guiding questions

Whose perspective structures the representation of childhood?

Are children represented through adult descriptions or interpretations?

Are children's own perspectives or voices present?

How are children positioned in relation to parents, families, schools, institutions, or other adults?

Are children's experiences interpreted primarily through adult concerns?

What aspects of childhood become visible through an adult-centred framing?

What might remain marginalised or absent as a result?

Fieldnotes

- Dominant perspective:
- Adult framing:
- Children's perspective/voice:
- Institutional framing:
- Relevant observations:

Curatorial framing and multimodal display

Observation focus

How objects, texts, images, spatial arrangements, and other display elements work together.

Guiding questions

How do objects and texts interact?

How does spatial placement affect the interpretation of an object or representation?

What visual elements draw attention to particular representations?

Are some objects or narratives given greater prominence than others?

How do different display elements reinforce or complicate one another?

How does the overall arrangement frame children's experiences?

Fieldnotes

- Object/text relationship:
- Spatial relationship:
- Visual emphasis:
- Narrative connection:
- Relevant observations:
- Photographic documentation
- Photograph(s) taken:
- Photograph reference:
- Purpose of photograph:

Children's visibility and absence

Observation focus

The presence, prominence, marginalisation, or absence of children and childhood within the exhibition.

Guiding questions

Where are children explicitly represented?

Where are children represented only indirectly?

How frequently do children appear in relation to adults?

Are particular childhood experiences more visible than others?

Are particular groups of children visible or absent?

Are children present as historical subjects, social actors, family members, consumers, workers, students, or in other roles?

Are there sections where childhood is absent despite potentially relevant historical themes?

Fieldnotes

- Visible representations:

- Indirect representations:

- Marginalised representations:

- Notable absences:

- Groups/experiences represented:

- Groups/experiences absent:

- Relevant observations:

Children's perspectives: inclusion, marginalisation, and absence

Observation focus

The presence or absence of children's own perspectives within the exhibition.

Guiding questions

Are children's own voices represented?

Are quotations, testimonies, photographs, writings, or other materials attributed to children?

Are children's experiences interpreted for them through adult voices?

Are children presented as subjects with their own perspectives or primarily as objects of adult knowledge?

Where are children's perspectives particularly visible?

Where are they marginalised or absent?

What effect does this have on the representation of childhood?

Fieldnotes

- Children's voices/perspectives:

- Form of inclusion:

- Marginalisation:

- Absence:

- Relevant observations: